What the Heart Wants

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28031367.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Angst, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Post-Canon, Separations, Heartache, Autistic Entrapta (She-Ra), Reunions, Friendship/Love, Beast Island (She-Ra), Banishment, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Hordak has self-worth issues, Entrapta makes a choice

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by Solitude_Rising

Summary

Post-canon fic. After the defeat of the galactic Horde, the kingdoms of Etheria have settled into a new time of peace. Entrapta has returned to Dryl to assume rulership once more and rebuild with Catra's assistance. Now without an empire and a refugee in the one-time Fright Zone alongside his stranded clone brothers, Hordak makes a decision on his fate which forces Entrapta to consider what is truly important to her.

Notes

Welcome to my new post-Season 5 fic, readers! For those of you who have been following my previous Entrapta/Hordak-focused works (*Moments*, *Addendum* and *The Origin of Sin*), thanks for joining me again and I hope this one will be another enjoyable ride for you! If you're new to my works, I certainly hope you'll stick around and maybe check out some of my aforementioned fics!

I've written this fic as a 5-parter, but I may end up splitting it into more parts. The rating may go up in later chapers too, just to warn you. It's another Entrapdak-focused one, coz I just love writing these two!

This is my own personal take on how Entrapta and Hordak might end up on Beast Island as Noelle Stevenson has mentioned before on video. I've taken a somewhat different approach to many other fics where Hordak usually undergoes a public trial and/or makes reparations for the damage he has caused on Etheria, and adjusts to living cooperatively with the other princesses. I had a strange and unique idea on what might happen to Catra post-canon too.

Prepare yourselves for some angst and emotional pain in the first couple of chapters, folks. But I assure you, it'll all be worth it in the end!

See the end of the work for more notes

What the Heart Wants – Part 1

Chapter Summary

As the opening ball for the new Scorpion Kingdom approaches, Entrapta oversees the rebuilding of Dryl with the aid of Catra. In the Scorpion Kingdom, Hordak must blend with the other clones.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With a sharp intake of breath, she threw herself at him. Her arms wrapped around his waist. Her face pressed into his chest. And they swung in a circle as she joyfully cried out his name:

"HORDAAAK!"

She held onto him as tightly as she could as they spun together, never wanting to let him go.

When her feet touched the ground again, she looked up into his face. It was the face of every other clone of Horde Prime's, green eyes and white face and hair. But she knew it was him, the first leader of the Horde she had ever known, the Lord of the Fright Zone, her lab partner, her friend: Hordak. She saw it in the crease of his brow, in the intensity of his green eyes, in the falling strand of blanched hair upon his forehead - his unique, beautiful imperfections. And on his face, she saw something that she was not sure she had ever seen fully on him before: a smile.

Hordak was smiling. At her.

She felt tears prick at the corners of her eyes.

*"I'm **so** glad you're back! Oh, we have so much to talk about!"*

As the words tumbled out of her mouth, he did something else that was rare for him: he chuckled. An affectionate chuckle, low and quiet, just for her. It surprised and delighted her.

He was as happy to see her again as she was to see him.

At last, they were together again.

With all her heart, the Princess of Dryl wanted to stay with the once Lord of the Horde forever.

Entrapta's magenta eyes opened drowsily. She blinked away her blurred vision until a dark room with bright computer screens came into focus. Large crates and piles of metal parts stood around her.

She was back in her old lab in the Crypto Castle. She was back home in the kingdom of Dryl.

"Hope you're not in the habit of dozing off in your lab like this."

The familiar female voice prompted Entrapta to lift her head hastily from a table. She winced as she felt the side of her face throbbing from having been squashed on the hard surface for too long. Drool was leaking from the corner of her mouth and she brought a gloved hand up to wipe it away.

Before her, she saw the owner of the familiar female voice entering the lab through the password-protected doors: it was Catra.

It took a moment for Entrapta to remember why Catra was in her lab. She had been assisting her. Adora had postponed their plans to return to Space to help with Etheria's recovery after the defeat of the galactic Horde. Catra had offered to help her with rebuilding and resettling Dryl. It had been the ex-Horde feline woman's attempt to make amends for having wronged her before. Entrapta had already forgiven her of course, but she was always happy to accept help. The more hands, the better after all. It would make things go faster.

The young feline woman's dark brown hair had grown some since the time she had been Horde Prime's captive. It now reached just past her shoulders. No symbolic trace of her former allegiance to the Horde remained on her form-fitting black and burgundy outfit. An easy, lopsided smile now hung on her lips.

The young feline woman strolled up to Entrapta and leaned herself on the edge of the table that the princess had just risen from, crossing her arms.

"Hey, Entrapta," she greeted.

The lilac-haired princess rubbed the remnants of sleep from her eyes.

"Oh, hey, Catra," she replied.

The feline woman produced a data pad from under an arm and held it out to her.

"I've completed a full list of all the ex-Horde members wanting to stay in Dryl," she informed as Entrapta accepted the data pad with a tendril of lilac hair, "everyone who was occupying the kingdom during its time under Horde rule."

Catra looked away. "They're currently staying in shelters. With your permission, I'll start looking into new living arrangements and roles for them. They'll be integrated into Drylian society and contribute to its rebuilding."

Entrapta nodded as she skimmed over the names on the data pad screen. "Uh huh. Sounds good. The Horde forces that occupied Dryl looked after it so well. I'm perfectly happy to let them stay."

She handed the data pad back to Catra with her hair tendril, then clapped her hands together. "And I'm sure they'll fit in in no time seen as how they've been here for so long already!"

Catra tucked the data pad back under her arm. "That's…really good of you, Entrapta."

“It’s practical!” Entrapta responded factually. “The ex-Horde residents will be highly useful additions to the workforce! Dryl’s operations will be able to expand and productivity will increase substantially!”

Catra’s blue and yellow eyes shifted away and she brought a hand up to hold her arm. “The former residents of Dryl might not be as welcoming of former Horde soldiers living alongside them.” There was a hint of discomfort in her voice.

Entrapta looked at her with a puzzled frown. “Why would they have a problem? They’re not Horde soldiers now and they’re not invading anymore. They’ll be helping to rebuild Dryl and increase production. And surely there’s enough space to accommodate them. If not, we can just build more homes for them.”

Without looking at the long-haired princess, Catra sighed. She bit back her first response on Entrapta’s naivety before choosing her words more carefully:

“Entrapta, the former residents of Dryl fled the kingdom when the Horde moved in. They were forced from their homes. People don’t usually forget about something like that easily.”

Entrapta’s expression fell and her head and pigtails lowered. “Oh…”

They fell silent, not looking at one another, unsure of what to say. Catra brought a hand up to her head and smoothed her hair back. She closed her eyes and inhaled, then brought her eyes back to Entrapta.

“It’ll take time,” she said reassuringly, “but Dryl’s people will come to accept the ex-Horde as part of their community. As their princess, you need to help them understand that the ex-Horde are people just like them, and deserve to be treated fairly and with compassion. You need to encourage them to give people from the Horde a chance to become a part of society.”

Entrapta looked back at her. A small smile formed on her lips.

“You…know a lot about this…don’t you?” she said quietly, “about people…and how to lead them…”

Catra turned her head away, hiding her discomfort, and crossed her arms. “Yeah, well…I’ve had plenty of experience from the Horde…not that I’m proud of it...”

Entrapta stood from her seat at the table, her magenta gaze fixed on Catra.

“But you learnt from it,” she pointed out. “You learnt how to lead people. And that’s useful.”

Catra glanced back at her. “Yeah…I guess it is,” she replied cautiously.

Entrapta’s magenta eyes descended to her table cluttered with tools and parts.

“I’m a princess,” she said tonelessly, “but I’ve never really been good at understanding people. I was always good with science and tech, but people were always difficult for me…” Her voice trailed off as she stared down blankly at the cluttered table beneath her.

Then her eyes snapped back up to Catra and an all-too-bright smile spread across her lips. “So, it’s a good thing you’re here now to help me with that!” she declared cheerfully.

Catra had leaned back and her ears twitched in surprise at the princess’ abrupt mood change. “Um, sure…Glad to be of help to you, Entrapta.”

Entrapta suddenly stilled. Her lilac pigtails puffed up and her magenta eyes lit up. “You could run the kingdom, Catra!” she blurted. “I mean you did it before in the Horde! You could do it here too!”

Catra nearly fell off the table she was leaning against in shock, but quickly recomposed herself and began to laugh.

“Oh, that’s a good one, Entrapta,” she chuckled. “I’m not the princess here though.” Her laughter died down and an appreciative smile formed on her lips. “But thanks for the confidence.”

Catra’s eyes moved up to a digital clock on a wall. It was approaching evening.

“I’ll have to go,” she announced, pushing herself off the table. “Adora and I need to get ready for Scor-” She corrected herself: “Um, **Princess** Scorpia’s new kingdom opening party.” She glanced at Entrapta. “See you there?”

Entrapta had been staring oddly at the feline woman, but blinked at her question. “Hm? Oh, right! Yes! Scorpia’s opening party!” Her voice rose with enthusiasm along with a broad smile. “I’ll be there! I haven’t been back to the Fright Zone in ages!”

Catra frowned at her. “It’s not the Fright Zone anymore,” she reminded flatly. “It’s the Scorpion Kingdom now.”

“Right! Of course! The Scorpion Kingdom!” Entrapta replied hastily.

Catra turned and took a step toward the lab doors, but then stopped and looked back at Entrapta curiously.

“Do you…have a plus one to go with?” she asked carefully.

Entrapta raised herself up on long legs of her lilac hair and began moving over to a large computer screen with video images.

“Nope!” she replied brightly. “But don’t worry! I’ll find Hordak when I get there! We’ve got so much to talk about!”

A small smile rose on her lips and, for a moment, she appeared to vibrate energetically, her gloved hands quaking subtly at her sides.

Catra's eyes dropped to the floor and her hand rose to the back of her head, rubbing her hair awkwardly.

"Yeah, Hordak…," she muttered. "I think he'll need to talk to you…"

Her discomfort went unnoticed by Entrapta as the princess settled herself in front of the large computer screen on a seat of her hair, scanning live video images of ongoing work around the Crypto Castle. She continued to talk excitedly:

"And whilst I'm there, I can also check on how Wrong Hordak and the other clones have been getting on since they moved into Scorpia's kingdom! It'll be so much fun to see them again too!"

Catra's eyes shifted sideways as she muttered less than enthusiastically: "Yeah, fun…"

Then her gaze returned to Entrapta, a questioning look in her blue and yellow eyes.

"Entrapta," she began hesitantly, "about Hordak, are you and he…" She trailed off.

Entrapta's silhouette remained motionless. She did not turn around from her computer screen.

"Never mind," Catra said instead, turning to leave. "I'll see you there then."

With a final glance over her shoulder back at the tech princess, Catra exited the lab.

Alone again, Entrapta stared at a live video feed on the large computer screen. She watched as a Dryl worker re-attached an old flag to the top of a pole on one of the castle's turrets. The flag was in Dryl's signature purple colours and depicted an eight-point star within a large cog, the crest of Dryl. Crumpled on the ground beneath the worker was another flag, dark blue with the vivid red wings of the Horde.

Entrapta looked away from the screen, hitting an escape button on the keyboard beneath her with a strand of hair and shutting off the video feeds. She did not feel like watching them anymore. Instead, she brought up another image on the screen: an outline of Hordak in the armour she had built for him before their separation. She gazed fondly at his digital visage, a smile manifesting on her lips. She drifted closer to him on her hair, reaching out with tentative fingers to touch his image tenderly.

She had waited so long to be reunited with him, surviving abandonment and searching tirelessly across the stars for him. And he in turn had endured pain and rebelled against his brother for her. So much had they struggled and suffered for one another. And after been apart for so long, to finally see and hold each other again had been worth everything they had been through.

Now, she could wait just a little bit longer to see him again. They would find one another again.

They would be together again. She was sure of it.

The turnout for the Scorpion kingdom's opening ball was impressive. The banquet hall of the converted Horde base, now the new 'Scorpion Castle', was packed. Royal and prestigious guests from all over Etheria had arrived to celebrate the reinstatement of the Scorpion Kingdom and its princess to the throne. They had gathered to celebrate Princess Scorpia.

Ruminating as he wandered through the crowds of party guests, Hordak kept his head low, avoiding eye contact. He had to keep a low profile now.

He had returned, along with many of his brothers, to what had been his domain, his seat of power on Etheria. This was the place he had built an army and empire from, where he had survived, away from Horde Prime, for years in.

But the Fright Zone was no more. And no longer was he the feared Lord of the Horde. The kingdom had been returned to the royal family that he had conquered it from so long ago. It now belonged to his former Force Captain: Princess Scorpia. This was now her kingdom. And like all his displaced brothers, he was now a guest here.

How things had changed.

Amongst his brothers, Hordak hid in plain sight, just another clone of Horde Prime left behind on Etheria. Unlike his brothers though, he had not retained green eyes. The artificial green had faded not long after the withdrawal of the Horde's source of sustenance, giving way to his mutant red again. The amniotic fluid that all Horde clones had been fed had contained chemicals that induced green pigmentation in their blood. It had effectively suppressed the expression of his defective mutation that gave him red blood and eyes in contrast to the green blood and eyes of his brothers. When the green pigment-inducing chemicals had worn off, his eyes and blood had turned a vivid red again. His 'purer', non-defective brothers were truer copies of Horde Prime though, and had remained naturally green-eyed as their progenitor had been.

He had begun painting dark shadows around his eyes and wearing black on his lips again. His hair was dyed dark blue again too. This had inspired several of his brothers to experiment with altering their appearance as well, adding new colours to their hair and faces. Shades of blue, red, purple, green, orange, yellow and browns abounded amongst them now.

It was through a new lens of freedom that Hordak now looked at himself. Horde Prime was gone, and he was free to be whatever he chose to be now. He was free to reclaim the name he had given himself long ago.

He was Hordak once more.

But that name and identity came with burdens and consequences.

No longer did he hold power, but the people of Etheria remembered him, remembered his war against the Rebellion and Princesses, his Horde's conquest of much of Etheria, his wrongs against them and their world.

No longer could he be seen. He had no place in this new world.

The chatter of party guests filtered into his sensitive ears as he drifted through the crowds.

"I don't think it's safe for all these Horde clones to walk around unmonitored."

Hordak's long ears rose at the lowered voice of a horned female ahead of him.

"Shouldn't they at least be tagged or something?" she was saying in a hushed manner to four other guests. "What if they go fanatical and decide to form an army again? What if they just decide to take over Etheria for themselves? For all we know, they might already be planning it."

"I've heard that they were brainwashed," a winged male responded in kind. "Are they even mentally stable?"

"If you ask me, all those Horde clones ought to be shipped off our world and dumped elsewhere in the universe!" a long-eared male uttered harshly. "After what Etheria has been put through at the hands of the Horde, why should we have to deal with their mess?"

Hordak hastened his pace, trying to move away from the group quickly. He knocked into the shoulder of the long-eared man as he pushed past.

"Apologies-" he started to say.

The long-eared man turned to face him.

"Look where you're going, Horde-"

He froze as he laid eyes on Hordak.

The entire group followed suit, staring at Hordak with widening eyes and opening mouths. A tense silence fell between them.

Finally, the long-eared man began to stutter: "You…You look like-"

"Another Horde clone, yes," Hordak promptly interjected.

His red gaze lowered to the long-eared man's hands that held an empty, dripping glass. Next to them was a large wet patch on the man's suit.

"You appear to have spilled your drink," Hordak observed. "May I fetch you a napkin and another beverage?"

The long-eared man drew back quickly. "No, no! It's fine!" He was waving a hand at him now. A nervous grin was plastered to his face. "Forget it! It's nothing, really!"

Hordak stepped back to give him space. "As you wish," he replied.

Hordak left the wide-eyed group behind and continued through the crowds, eager to find respite from the people around him.

He glided through a doorway and into an empty corridor. He walked for a minute down the carpeted corridor, then reached out a hand to a wall and leaned himself against it, slumping with exhaustion. One hand rose to hold the side of his ribs. It had begun to ache of late, a dull throb in his side when he overexerted himself. It seemed his physical defect was manifesting once again.

He sighed tiredly. He raised his eyes to a window pane beside him and caught his reflection in it.

His angular white face was that of every clone of Horde Prime. But his vivid red eyes burned from the painted shadows around them. If not for his red-eyed mutation and genetic defects, he would have been like all his other brothers: healthy, perfect,

indistinguishable. He would not have been discarded by his big brother.

Horde Prime would still be alive, would still command him.

He would never have been freed.

Autonomy was a heavy cross to bear. And yet, he could no longer live without it. Never could he be a slave to the will of another again.

Amongst the shared faces of his brothers, he could disappear. Lord Hordak of the Fright Zone could cease to be.

Within himself, he felt it though, how he differed from his brothers, not just in his defective body, but in his mind and heart too. He was changed by his time on this world, by his memories.

He was tainted. He was an abomination. He was imperfect. He was the one who had turned against Horde Prime. He was the one who had killed him in body.

Hated, reviled and feared, but slave to no-one. He was Hordak.

Chapter End Notes

> Something that the show never touched on, but which I've alluded to here, is that Dryl has been without a princess and under Horde control since the second season of the show. I imagine a lot of things would have changed there in that time. It could have essentially become home to the Horde soldiers that were occupying the kingdom during that period. Assuming that Dryl had a native population before its takeover by the Etherian Horde, I see returning Drylians potentially having to integrate with the occupying Horde forces (because Princess Entrapta, being as compassionate as she is, surely would have no desire to force them out).
>
> I also figured that it would make the most sense and be the most practical for Scorpia if she simply used existing Horde

structures and resources when reclaiming her kingdom, as opposed to rebuilding it all from scratch. Remember that she grew up in the Horde as well, so the Fright Zone is what she will be familiar with.

Next chapter, Entrapta arrives at the Scorpion Kingdom ball.

What the Heart Wants – Part 2

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta arrives at the Scorpion Kingdom’s opening ball and reconnects to friends old and new. Whilst there, she learns of Hordak's plans.

Chapter Notes

> Christmas is just around the corner. Wherever you all are, I hope you are warm, safe and loved. Even if you can't celebrate with others, I hope you can give yourselves the rest, care and happiness you deserve.
>
> Going to be splitting future updates into smaller chunks I think. It's now looking like this might be a 9-parter!
>
> Thanks so much for your kudos and comments on the first chapter, folks! I really appreciate the support of returning readers! Hope to keep your interest!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The last major social event Entrapta had attended had been the Princess Prom at the Kingdom of Snows. It had been a prime opportunity for her to observe the social behaviour and interactions between the princesses and other members of high society. Going in her usual workwear had been practical, allowing her manoeuvrability as she moved around to watch the proceedings from different vantage points. Wearing a dress would have simply hindered her.

This time was different though. This time, she wanted to participate directly in social interactions. This time, Hordak would be there.

And so, she had made an effort to make herself more presentable for the Scorpion Kingdom’s opening ball. It was a formal event

that required an appropriate dress. She had spent time researching eveningwear to find something suitable, something that would enhance her appearance, something that might even impress Hordak.

Her search for an appropriate evening dress had produced the garment she now wore: a full-length lavender purple dress accompanied by a matching pair of gloves that rose past her elbows. A choker of the same colour with a magenta gem at its front sat around her neck. Her pigtails had been tied up into two large buns with loose lengths of lilac hair hanging down from them.

Appropriately attired, the Princess of Dryl entered the crowded banquet hall of the new Scorpion Castle. As she did, an enthusiastic female voice called out:

"Entrapta!"

She looked in the direction of the voice that had called her name and saw Scorpia in a sleek black and red dress barrelling toward her with raised pincer arms. Perfuma, in a lush green dress, trailed behind her with a smile. Before Entrapta could respond, Scorpia scooped her up in her large arms.

"I'm so happy to see you again!" the scorpion princess declared, squeezing Entrapta in a tight hug.

The contact took her by surprise and Entrapta squirmed slightly in the larger princess' tight hold, but she patted her friend's head with a strand of her lilac hair.

"Good to see you too, Scorpia!" she replied brightly as the scorpion princess set her back down on her feet. "Great idea repurposing the Horde headquarters to be your new castle!" She looked around herself at the surrounding hall. "Much more efficient than building from scratch! And you can just use existing Horde power and resources!" She raised her arms and pigtails for emphasis.

“Well, there were a few repairs that needed to be done around Hordak’s old Sanctum,” Scorpia informed conversationally, “and we did quite a bit of refurbishing and redecorating which Perfuma had a big hand in.” She looked to Perfuma who was standing beside her with a smile. The flower princess returned her smile as they gazed happily into one another’s eyes.

After a moment of gazing at one another, Scorpia blushed and looked back to Entrapta. “Sorry, didn’t mean to-”

She and Perfuma blinked in surprise when they saw an empty space in front of them. Entrapta had disappeared.

“Wandered off again,” Perfuma sighed with an unsurprised frown.

“That’s how she is,” Scorpia replied with a knowing smile. “Comes and goes as she pleases.”

Holding her elbow out to the flower princess, Scorpia led Perfuma back through the crowds to converse with other guests.

Scorpia and Perfuma had evidently been engaged with staring at one another, so Entrapta had quietly left them alone. No need to disturb them further. Besides, she had someone else to look for.

She now found herself heading toward the long buffet tables spread with food and drink. As she moved through crowds of party guests, she surveyed the several Horde clones scattered around the hall. Her eyes stopped at a clone with vibrant blue hair by the buffet tables. Excitedly, she moved toward him.

“Hordak?” she called as she approached him from behind.

The clone turned around to reveal beaming green eyes and a bright smile.

“Greetings, Entrapta!” he called back with a wink and a wave.

She beamed back at him and returned his wave with a hand-shaped tuft of hair.

"Wrong Hordak!" she greeted enthusiastically. "Sorry, I thought you were Hordak! You kinda looked like him from behind!"

"To be compared in appearance with our enlightened brother is a compliment!" he declared proudly. "I have even chosen to colour my hair in honour of him!"

"That's so sweet!" Entrapta cooed. Then she looked away in thought and tapped her chin with a finger. "Although it does make telling you apart a little harder."

The clone's green eyes swept down her lavender dress.

"You are also looking particularly aesthetically pleasing this evening," he remarked.

Her focus returned to him and she emitted a nervous laugh.

"Thanks," she replied with a light blush. "Listen, it's great to see you again, Wrong Hordak, but I really want to find Hordak. Have you seen him?"

"I believe Brother Hordak may have been exhausted by the party environment." His green gaze moved to an open doorway of the hall. "I observed him leaving the hall a short while ago. He is most likely recuperating at the balcony."

Entrapta began to turn toward the doorway. "Thanks. I'll go and check. Catch you later, Wrong Hordak!"

The clone waved to her with a smile as she left to head for the doorway. As she weaved past party guests, she came upon Adora, Catra, Bow and Glimmer who were standing together and chatting. They looked at her as she appeared and exchanged furtive glances with one another. Then Bow raised an arm and waved at her.

“Hey, Entrapta!” he called. “Come join us!”

“Sorry, I’m looking for Hordak!” she called back hurriedly, moving past them. “Maybe later!” She waved back to them with a hair hand as she left them behind.

They exchanged nervous looks again as they watched her disappearing through the doorway.

Entrapta wandered down the carpeted corridor until she felt a cool breeze touch her skin. It was coming from an archway to her left that led outside. She could see the night sky beyond it. Turning, she walked through the archway, emerging from the corridor onto a large balcony. Ahead of her, at the end of the balcony, she saw a Horde clone in dark garments leaning over the balustrade, looking out into the star-filled night sky.

“Hordak?” she called softly.

The clone did not respond. He did not turn around.

“It’s you, isn’t it?” Entrapta pressed, inching closer. “I’ve been looking all over for you!”

He seemed to hesitate, but slowly turned to face her. He was in a long, plain, navy blue dress with high side slits revealing his black legging-clad thighs. No longer did he bear the winged symbol of the Horde. His arms were coated by long black sleeves. A black shawl covered his broad shoulders, fastened by the First Ones-inscribed crystal she had installed in his armour long ago. The diamond-shaped fuchsia crystal now shone from his chest as a centrepiece brooch.

From under long, curved strands of dark blue hair, his shadow-encircled vibrant red eyes landed on her, widening slightly. His breath hitched.

“Entrapta…,” he uttered.

He gazed at her wordlessly, his red eyes taking in her lavender-draped form.

It was a moment before he spoke again: "You look…impressive."

Entrapta's magenta eyes shifted down to the floor as a shy smile spread over her lips. A blush bloomed on her cheeks. "Thanks. You look nice too."

He turned his head away. His long ears twitched.

A heavy silence descended. Entrapta looked down at her gloved fingers as she fiddled with them. Hordak kept his head to the side. His ears continued to twitch.

Then he turned his back to her.

"You…should be inside," he stated in a low voice, "enjoying the party with your...friends."

Entrapta looked up at him again. "I wanted to talk to **you**. We've been apart since…Horde Prime…We have so much catching up to do!"

Hordak kept his back to her. His voice was flat:

"There is nothing of importance to discuss. All is as it should be. Etheria and the wider universe are free of the Horde and the princesses have returned to their kingdoms to rebuild, including you. All is well."

Entrapta gave him a confused look.

"What about you?" she inquired softly. "You haven't told me what's been happening with you. Have you talked with Adora and the other princesses yet? Are you going to be staying here in Scorpia's kingdom?"

There was a pause before Hordak replied in a factual tone:

“I have spoken with the princesses. They gave me that option: to remain here incognito amongst my brothers, unseen by Etheria’s general populace, dismantling my former stronghold and returning the Fright Zone to its rightful princess…”

“Well…that’s good news!” Entrapta responded optimistically. “So, you can stay here in your old home-”

Hordak cut her off: “But I decided against that. I had no desire to remain here amongst the remnants of my failed empire, indistinct from my brothers…”

Entrapta stared at his broad back, unsure of where he was going with what he was saying.

“So…what did you decide?” she finally asked.

Hordak paused again. He was utterly still, keeping his eyes focused ahead.

“To send myself…to Beast Island,” he uttered almost inaudibly.

Chapter End Notes

The idea of Hordak going to Beast Island post-canon is not new. But I haven't seen anyone else considering the idea that he effectively banishes himself there. So, I'm trying it!

On Wrong Hordak, he's dyed his hair a lighter shade of blue than Hordak's. And yes, I'm aware of the popular name the fandom has created for him. That might come up later.

Next chapter, Entrapta reacts to Hordak's announcement.

What the Heart Wants – Part 3

Chapter Summary

> When Hordak announces his decision to send himself to Beast Island, what does this mean for Entrapta?

Chapter Notes

> Hope you've all had a warm and comforting Christmas and are ready to face the new year. Let's hope it brings better tidings!
>
> Thank you again for the kudos and comments. Glad to hear my idea of Hordak banishing himself has been well-received!
>
> Take heed, this update contains emotional pain and might cause heartache. You have been warned!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta froze.

"Beast Island?" she repeated slowly. "That's…pretty far away."

Hordak's back was turned to her. There was no response from him. He did not turn around to look at her.

Entrapta's gaze fell to the floor. She frowned then raised her eyes to him again.

"But you won't be leaving so soon, right?" she insisted. "I mean, you'll need time to research and properly prepare!" She began to pace as she talked. Her lilac hair curled and twisted beneath her buns. "There are a lot of dangerous things on that island: the technological monstrosities, the degraded First Ones tech, the mind-numbing signal from the centre-"

Hordak turned slowly to face her. She stopped talking to look at him. There was an expression on his face that she couldn't quite identify, but it made her hold her breath.

"I will be departing by the end of the month, as soon as preparations are complete," he informed in a low voice. "Princess Scorpia has granted me permission to take the old Horde sea vessels."

Her thoughts ceased. Her brain seemed to stop working. She suddenly didn't know what to say.

"Oh…," she finally managed, her voice small. "That's…sooner than I thought."

The unreadable expression on Hordak's face persisted. His red eyes were still and his mouth was a flat line, betraying no emotion.

"I am prepared," his head lowered and his red eyes narrowed to slits as his voice dropped to a rumble, "more so than you were when you were…sent there." His hands clenched into fists at his sides.

Entrapta's gloved hands squeezed restlessly at her sides as well. An unsettled expression disturbed her features as she looked at him. "You shouldn't go alone…," she began.

"I won't be alone," Hordak replied promptly, lifting his gaze to her again. "I am being accompanied by several of my brothers who have decided to join me. We will be a community of clones."

Entrapta looked away uncertainly, biting her lower lip, then back to him again. "What will you do there?"

"Study the island, make it habitable, settle there," he replied factually. His red gaze swept out over the edge of the balcony briefly before returning to her, "away from the rest of Etheria, where we will be of no trouble to people and where we may begin to build new lives for ourselves."

Suddenly, Entrapta's eyes widened and her lilac hair snapped up from under her buns. She brought her hands up in excited fists.

"I should come with you!" she declared brightly. "I know all about the island's terrain, creatures and technology! I could help you to-"

"**No!**"

Hordak's abrupt interruption caused her to stare at him in surprise.

"No, Entrapta," he repeated, subduing his voice. "You are…needed here. You are a princess of Etheria. You have a kingdom to rule and rebuild. You…belong with the other princesses."

The dispirited look she gave him made his chest ache.

"But…you'll come back to visit often, right?" she pressed hopefully. "We'll still get to work together, won't we?"

Something in Hordak's sombre red eyes told her what she didn't want to hear. Her heart plummeted into her stomach. His silence filled her with a growing terror.

"Hordak?" Her voice quivered. "We're still friends, aren't we?"

Hordak's large hands carefully reached out for her shoulders, laying so gently upon them she almost didn't notice them.

His voice was softer than she had ever heard: "Entrapta…"

She looked up at him with fearful eyes. His own eyes held hers as he brought a clawed fingertip to her cheek, hovering delicately over it.

"You have everything you need now," he said quietly, "your kingdom, the acceptance of the other princesses, status and respect as a saviour of Etheria…" He squeezed his eyes shut and inhaled audibly through his nasal cavity. His voice became firm:

"You have a reputation and image to preserve. It would be best for you to…distance yourself from…contentious company…"

Entrapta looked at him confused. "Contentious…what are you talking about, Hordak?"

"You must focus on strengthening your friendships with the other princesses and cementing your position in the Alliance," he continued tonelessly, "for your own good and the good of your kingdom. Continued association with a former warlord of the Horde would damage the other princesses' trust in you and hurt your public reputation."

Entrapta pulled away from him suddenly, her mouth falling open as she stared up at him in disbelief. "Hordak, that's ridiculous! Catra was just as destructive as you in the Horde, but she's been forgiven! And she and Adora are together now!"

Hordak watched her with a quiet resignation.

"I have been leader of the Horde on Etheria for much longer than Catra was," he replied all too calmly. "My deeds go back further than hers. She is young and can be more easily pardoned. And she has spent more time making up for her actions. I have…much to atone for...and little trust from others."

He turned his gaze, now a dull red, to look out over the balcony at a dark, star-filled horizon. "Hordak remains a figure of fear and distrust amongst Etheria's population. And all my brothers serve as visual reminders of Horde Prime's control. People are justifiably wary and resentful of us."

His gaze returned wearily to her. "That is why I have made the decision to remove myself and any of my willing brothers to Beast Island, so that we will no longer cause strife for the people of Etheria, and so that we may live quietly without judgement and disturbance."

Tears formed at the corners of Entrapta's eyes and she squeezed them shut. "It's…it's not fair…"

"On the contrary," Hordak replied dispassionately, "the one responsible for conquering much of Etheria in Horde Prime's name is to be banished to the very place that he once sent his enemies to die, and it is by his own decision. I believe many would consider that…fair."

His hand began to lift to her, but then stopped and lowered again. "Fairness is irrelevant here. This is how things are, whether we like it or not."

"But we…we have so much we could do…," Entrapta tried to reason. "I thought we would be-"

Hordak's brow creased and he shut his eyes tightly. His hands clenched into fists at his sides. His breathing grew heavier.

"Thank you for being my…friend, Entrapta," he ground out unsteadily. "Your friendship has been…significant to me."

He exhaled heavily and opened his eyes again, looking at her firmly. "This is for the best. You will understand when you have had time to consider."

Entrapta had tried to hold her feelings in. She did not like losing control of them. But something in her snapped at that moment and a tide of anger burst from her, pouring from her mouth:

"**Don't talk to me like that! Don't talk like you know better than me! That's what I get from others! People always telling me that they know what's best for me! Treating me like I'm a child! Like I don't know anything! Like I can't make decisions for myself!**"

The gates that held back her emotions flew open. A tide of feelings poured out, overwhelming her, and she was pleading desperately:

"**You were different, Hordak! You respected me! You listened to me! You treated me like an equal! We were partners! We were friends!**"

Her tears were flowing freely down her cheeks now. Her fisted hands shook with anger and despair.

"**We were separated for so long, first by Catra, then Horde Prime! And then, after we saved the planet and everyone, we finally were reunited! After everything we've been through, you're just going to disappear and never come back?**"

Uncontrolled sobs racked her body. Her ample bosom heaved with the strain of increased heavy breaths. She looked and felt ready to collapse.

"Hordak…don't leave…," she pleaded weakly, reaching for him with a hand and her hair tails, "don't leave me behind…again…"

Hordak spun away from her, breathing rapidly through gritted teeth. His hand clutched at his chest, over his heart. His voice came out strangled: "I…I…"

He could not be weak now. He could not allow himself to feel…

His clawed fingers found her fuchsia First Ones crystal attached to his chest. He grasped it like a talisman, squeezing it until the sharp corners of its edges pierced his flesh, causing bright red blood to dribble out of his clenched palm.

He had to…He had to be strong. He had to do what was right. He had to let her go now.

He summoned every last ounce of strength he had left and whipped back round to face her.

"**I used you!**" he bellowed, rising over her to cover her in his shadow. "**I valued returning to Horde Prime's side over your friendship! I used your knowledge and skills to build the portal machine! I allowed Catra to send you away! I believed her when she said you were a traitor! I sought to get back at you on the battlefield when you were trapped**

on Beast Island! I left you there! And when Horde Prime came, I denied you! I willingly gave you up for him!"

Entrapta stared up at him in paralysed horror. Her mouth hung open. The spark had died in her magenta eyes.

He truly was a monster.

Hordak fought to hold back his tears.

"**I am not a worthy friend, Entrapta!**" he snarled. "**I have failed you in every possible way! And you would do well to realise that!**"

He strode past her, heading for the archway leading back into the corridor.

"Hordak…," he heard her whimper frailly from behind him.

He paused in his strides, but did not turn to look at her. Bright red blood dripped from his clenched fist at his side.

"I do not deserve…your friendship…," he uttered bitterly. "You should find better friends…a better partner…than I…one who will not…fail you."

He resumed his departure, not looking back at her even once. "Good bye…Entrapta."

As he disappeared through the archway, leaving her alone on the balcony, Entrapta's knees finally gave way and she collapsed onto the floor, hugging herself and shaking uncontrollably. Her hair wrapped tightly around her body and she curled into a ball.

Drawing her knees into herself, she sobbed quietly into them:

"Hordak…don't leave me…here alone…"

Chapter End Notes

One of the things I wanted to get across here was how Hordak's self-banishment to Beast Island is an understandable and logical choice given the difficult circumstances he and the other clones find themselves in on Etheria now, but he is also harboring guilt and self-blame for the mistakes and bad choices he's made in the past.

I promise, things will get better in updates to come!

Next time, Entrapta speaks with the other princesses.

What the Heart Wants - Part 4

Chapter Summary

> Following the events of the Scorpion Kingdom's ball, Entrapta retreats to her lab. Concerned, the Princesses decide to check on her.

Chapter Notes

> Welcome to a new year all, though 2021's got off to a rocky start for many because of the worsening pandemic. Here's hoping for better times on the horizon.
>
> I'm glad the last chapter was well-received by readers, heart-wrenching as it was. Thank you so much for all the comments! I really hope my plan for this fic satisfies you all. Remember, it's always darkest before the dawn!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Beatrice Baker, Sodiat Popper and Busina Girllum stood at the ready when the wheeled butler bot rolled into the kitchen of the Crypto Castle carrying a tray. In turn, they set down the prepared food and drink they were carrying onto the robot's outstretched tray as it rolled by them, pausing for each person. Armed with a tray of bite-sized pastry snacks, mini purple cupcakes and a bottle of fizzy purple grape juice with a striped straw sticking out the top, the butler bot rolled out of the kitchen, watched by the castle's three kitchen staff.

As soon as the bot was gone, Beatrice Baker, a large-bodied woman with mint green hair in a magenta dress, looked to Sodiat Popper, a lavender-haired man with pointed ears dressed in a light green shirt and blue jacket, and Busina Girllum, a small young woman with blue hair in a white buttoned chef coat.

"Has she been out of her lab yet?" Baker asked with a note of concern.

Popper and Girllum shook their heads sadly.

“I haven’t seen her all week,” Girllum reported apologetically. “Not since her return from the Scorpion Kingdom’s ball.”

“She’s hiding more than usual,” Popper noted grimly. “Something happened at that ball.”

Baker, the longest-serving member of the kitchen staff, sighed, her broad shoulders dropping. “We just need to give her space and time,” she advised. “Princess Entrapta works through things at her own pace.”

Popper and Girllum exchanged uncertain glances, but nodded to Baker.

Entrapta was engrossed. She stood over a work table in her lab, focused on a data pad on the table beneath her. Her long lilac hair was branched around her, holding various tools and gadgets in her tendrils. She was reading aloud as she went through a list on the data pad screen:

“Hexdriver, check; blowtorch, check; wrench, check; wire clippers, check; laser cutter-”

Her list-checking was interrupted by the beeping of an incoming call alert from the main computer screen behind her. She turned around to look at it and sighed. Her hair tendrils set down all the tools and gadgets she had been carrying on the table, then raised her off the ground. On long lilac legs of hair, she made her way over to the largest computer screen in her lab and seated herself on her hair before it. She took a steadying breath, then reached for the controls with a gloved hand and pressed a button. Six video screen boxes containing the faces of the Princess Alliance popped up in two rows of three on the computer screen. They all smiled broadly at her.

“Hey, Entrapta!” Bow greeted enthusiastically from the video screen box in the middle of the lower row. Queen Glimmer was beside him. “Glad you could join us! The first Princess Alliance group video meeting! Isn’t this exciting?” He grinned a little too widely.

Entrapta stared at him blankly. “Sure.”

In the lower left corner next to Bow and Glimmer, Scorpia shifted. She was accompanied by Perfuma.

“So, um, Entrapta,” the Scorpion princess began hesitantly, “how’ve you been?”

“Alive,” Entrapta replied factually.

Scorpia laughed nervously. “Okay, that’s good…Me too.”

“Have you been eating and sleeping well, Entrapta?” Perfuma asked anxiously from next to Scorpia. “Diet and regular rest are crucial for wellbe-”

“Sorry, but what is this meeting for?” Entrapta interrupted with a touch of impatience, a puzzled frown on her features. “I was kind of in the middle of something.”

Surely the princesses hadn’t called a group meeting just for a social chat? She had more important things to be getting on with.

Across the six video screen boxes, the princesses and their partners awkwardly shifted their gazes away from the Princess of Dryl. Adora exchanged a silent glance with Catra beside her before speaking from the middle of the upper row:

“Entrapta, we haven’t heard from you since Scorpia’s party,” she said seriously. “You’ve not replied to our messages, and you’ve not allowed Catra back into Dryl to help you.”

Troubled expressions hung on both Catra and Adora’s faces as Adora spoke.

Entrapta looked down. A strand of her hair went to her insectoid mask atop her head and fiddled with its straps.

"Sorry. Been occupied," she replied simply.

"We're…concerned about you, Entrapta," Glimmer continued carefully from the centre of the lower row, beneath Adora and Catra. "Are you okay?"

Entrapta's eyes remained directed at the floor. Her strand of hair slid over the top edges of her mask.

"I'm perfectly fine, as you can see," she replied vaguely.

In their video screen box, Glimmer and Bow looked at one another, then returned their gazes to her.

"Did…Hordak talk to you at the party?" Bow asked cautiously.

Entrapta froze. With a push from her strand of hair, her insectoid mask slammed down over her face. The couples on the screen: Adora and Catra, Bow and Glimmer, Scorpia and Perfuma, and Spinerella and Netossa, exchanged nervous glances between themselves. Mermista and Frosta's brows furrowed at the upper corners of the screen.

"We're sorry we didn't tell you earlier…about Hordak's decision to go to Beast Island," Adora said slowly, watching Entrapta worriedly. "He didn't want us to say anything though."

Entrapta did not respond. Her shoulders were hunched and her masked face was pointed down.

"Do you want to...talk about it?" Adora asked uncertainly.

Entrapta remained silent and statuesque.

"If you're upset, it's good to talk about it," Bow pressed gently.

Almost imperceptibly, Entrapta's masked face lifted to the screen. Her turquoise lenses glared brightly in the light of the computer screen.

"What makes you think I'm upset?" she uttered flatly.

There was a tense pause. Then Adora spoke again:

"We gave Hordak the option to remain in Scorpia's kingdom amongst his brothers," she explained cautiously, "where no-one would immediately recognise him, and where Scorpia could…" She hesitated. "…look after him."

"You mean keep an eye on him," Entrapta stated plainly.

The princesses' gazes moved away uncomfortably again.

"We recognised your account of Hordak's role in defeating Horde Prime and considered his…'conditioning' at Prime's hands," Glimmer informed solemnly. "But Hordak was the leader of the Horde on Etheria for many years before Prime's arrival, and he was responsible for conquering nearly half the planet. His history and reputation on Etheria are…complicated. Letting him operate freely without supervision or monitoring was not really an option. We can't be sure if he's…," she paused, choosing her next words carefully, "completely changed."

Entrapta's voice was hollow from the mechanical glare of her insectoid mask:

"So, he had to be kept with the other Horde clones and watched...because you can't trust him."

"It was for his own safety too," Glimmer insisted. "Not everyone on Etheria might be so willing to forgive him for his past actions."

Entrapta's head lowered at the young queen's words.

"I know it might not seem fair on him, Entrapta," Adora offered sympathetically, "but we didn't have many options. In the end

though, it was his own suggestion to exile himself to Beast Island. He agreed to remain on the island and never to pose a threat to the rest of Etheria again. And it turned out that several of his brothers wanted to follow him."

"He didn't have much choice…," Entrapta murmured to herself.

"Entrapta, we know you were friends with him, and it may be hard to let him go," Bow said gently. "But Hordak's made his choice, and we should accept that."

"He's made a sensible decision," Netossa commented from the lower right corner of the screen. "Etheria's been through two waves of Horde invasions from Hordak's and then Horde Prime's armies. People are still distrustful of the Horde clones. If some of them can stay on Beast Island, they'll be safely out of sight from the rest of Etheria, and they'll be able to live without disturbance. It might be the best solution for all at this time."

"And no offense, geek princess," Mermista drawled from the upper left corner of the screen, folding her arms, "but considering the kingdoms and towns he's razed to the ground and the people he's hurt in the past, my own included, I'd say Hordak's been lucky to get off pretty easy. So long as I don't have to invite him to Salineas' next undersea ball though, I'm not complaining."

Entrapta's head remained lowered. She said nothing as the other princesses on the screen watched her.

"Entrapta, we're all your friends and we're here for you if you need us," Adora offered.

"We're princesses, and princesses stick together," Glimmer added.

"You should get out more, meet more people," Perfuma suggested with an encouraging smile. "You could come visit when Scorpia and I are together in Plumeria! We'd be happy to have you join us for tea! And we could give you a tour and introduce you to some lovely folk!"

“And you know I could always use some input from you on improving my tech,” Bow chipped in positively. “I’m still trying to work on something to show at the next Makers Guild conference!”

Strands of Entrapta’s lilac hair twisted at her sides. Her gloved hands squeezed into fists in her lap. “Oh, that’s nice of you all, but I really am busy.”

She reached for the computer’s controls with a strand of hair. “Sorry, gotta go now. Bye.” She quickly waved at the princesses with another strand of hair.

“Entrapta-” Adora started to say.

She was cut off abruptly as Entrapta’s hair strand pressed a button, shutting off the video screens and ending the virtual group meeting.

The tech princess turned her attention back to the table where she had left all her previously collected tools and gadgets before the video call interruption. Moving back swiftly to the table on long legs of her hair, she picked up the data pad and resumed scanning the list on it. Quickly engrossing herself in list-checking again, she picked up the tools and gadgets on the table with tendrils of her hair and began depositing them into a small purple toolbox sitting open on the side of the table.

Dropping the last tool into the box and shutting it with a hair strand, she laid the data pad back down on the table and looked up, a determined expression on her face.

“Emily!” she called suddenly, turning to locate her reprogrammed Horde drone companion. “I need you to record something for me!”

Chapter End Notes

> The Princesses were not the ones to 'punish' Hordak here as many might imagine, given that they opposed one another for so long. It was Hordak's decision to sentence himself to

self-exile and the Princesses accepted it. The Princesses neither caused nor challenged it. Hordak had understandable reasons for his decision: to remove himself and his clone brothers to somewhere away from the rest of Etheria's population, for the safety and wellbeing of both sides; to give himself a fresh start in a new place; and as fair penance for the harm he has caused Etheria. In regards to Entrapta, he holds his greatest regrets for his failures to adequately return her friendship. And because of their different positions now, he believes that she would be better off without him.

Next chapter, Hordak prepares for depature.

What the Heart Wants - Part 5

Chapter Summary

As Hordak prepares for departure to Beast Island, he shares final words with Catra and bids farewell to the Princesses.

Chapter Notes

Something that I want readers to know: this isn't a redemption story. Hordak's story arc in the show was never about him repenting for his evil actions. His story was one of finding free will and a different type of connection than the one he had with his controlling big brother. This post-canon fic sees Hordak using his newfound free will after his liberation from Horde Prime to make a significant decision for himself: to exile himself to Beast Island. It's not so much a decision he's made to punish himself for his past deeds, but more to find his rightful place in the world, somewhere where he can begin anew, free from the judgement and control of others. Here we witness the beginnings of Hordak's independence and ability to choose his own fate. The morality and ethics of his and other characters' decisions and actions in this fic are not so important. This is not about whether Hordak's choices are right or wrong, but about him making the best choice for himself in his current circumstances.

Hordak and Entrapta have always been morally tricky. Seen as evil and weird by others, but unique and beautiful by one another. Their difficulties arise from the stark differences between their own views and the views of others. Entrapta's decision to join the Horde was an act of betrayal and morally wrong to the other Princesses, but for Entrapta herself, it was a good decision that allowed her to find new passions and friends. Hordak's attempts to conquer Etheria were morally reprehensible to those he wronged, but for Hordak himself, he believed he was doing the right thing to prove his worth to his brother. When there is such a disconnect between one's

> perceptions and those of others, when one finds that they do not fit with the common views of those around them, when one's wishes differ radically from others, what are we to do? What choices do we have?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The time had come for Hordak and his brothers to depart.

Horde clones came and went from a fleet of old Horde sea vessels docked at the coast of the Scorpion Kingdom. They carried heavy cargo, metal crates filled with supplies, up ramps and loaded them onto the decks of the old Horde ships, depositing them in neat stacks. Clones on the ships picked up the stacked crates and brought them below deck for storage.

Upon the shore, Hordak stood silently, imposing in his high-slitted navy blue dress with black shawl, sleeves and leggings, watching his clone brothers moving to and from the old Horde ships. His midnight blue hair flowed in the sea breeze. He lifted a hand to the shining fuchsia First Ones crystal on his chest. His red eyes closed as his clawed fingers tenderly touched the First Ones symbols etched onto the crystal’s surface.

“Hey, Hordak.”

His red eyes snapped open at the call of his name by a voice he wanted never to hear again. His brow creased in displeasure and a low growl in his throat was suppressed. His eyes flared a vivid scarlet momentarily before fading back to a soft red glow. He inhaled deeply through his nasal cavity and slowly released it.

“Catra,” he acknowledged in a controlled tone.

He turned to face the feline woman who had once served as his second-in-command. She stood a cautious distance from him, blue and yellow eyes cast down, nervously holding onto an arm, her tail swishing restlessly behind her. Some distance away behind her, Adora stood patiently observing, far enough to grant them privacy from ears, but near enough to watch them. Seated next to

her was the strange magical cat creature from Krytis known as 'Melog', transparent blue tail flicking behind them as they carefully watched them as well. Catra glanced back at Adora briefly before returning her heterochromatic gaze to her former commander.

For a few moments, the former co-leaders of the Etherian Horde simply watched one another tensely.

Then Catra broke the silence: "Guess I should say something before you head off to Beast Island for good."

"I am listening," Hordak replied simply.

Catra took a steadying breath. Her eyes darted away. "I'm…sorry… for everything from before…I did some pretty bad things to you…" She drew her shoulders in, making herself smaller. "I don't expect you to forgive me."

Another tense silence filled the space between them.

A crease appeared on Hordak's brow and his red eyes narrowed.

He remembered, oh how he remembered, **vividly**, Catra's treachery, how she had lied to him, over and over, telling him that Entrapta was a traitor, hiding from him the truth that she had sent her to Beast Island, to her doom. How well Shadow Weaver had taught her in the art of deception. How expertly she had weaved that lie to gain his dependence and trust, to manipulate him to her will over the course of so many months, months that Entrapta had spent alone, surviving on an island of death, believing he had abandoned her like the Princesses had.

Learning the truth from the shapeshifter, that Catra had deceived him, that Entrapta was gone, had shattered his world, leaving him with nothing but all-consuming hatred and grief. His final moments before been brought back into Horde Prime's light had been filled with so much rage and agony because of Catra. His long strived for return to his brother had been a far cry from the triumphant moment that he had envisioned. Instead, he had been brought back before his brother a broken man, having lost

everything: his empire, his strength…his only friend. Catra had dragged him down the path of self-destruction with her. She had been his ruin, his downfall.

He squeezed his eyes shut, gritting his sharp red teeth as he felt the embers of his old anger grow hot again.

Entrapta had forgiven her though, he remembered.

Drawing in a calming breath and then slowly exhaling, he let the fire within diminish and die, allowing his anger to pass.

If Entrapta had forgiven her, he had to as well.

When Hordak opened his eyes again, he glared sternly at Catra, responding evenly:

"Your apology does not diminish the severity of your actions, but it is nonetheless accepted." He paused, his red eyes descending to the ground. "And for your role in reminding me of who I was whilst we were on the Horde flagship…" His voice lowered. "I thank you."

Catra's eyes widened in surprise at him, then quickly retreated sideways as her eyebrows drew together in agitation.

"You shouldn't be thanking me for that," she muttered uncomfortably. "Not after…what you went through…after I called you by your name." She frowned deeply. Unconsciously, her hand reached up to the back of her neck and pressed on the spot where she had once been chipped. "Horde Prime's purification…It was worse than any of your punishments…You were made to suffer because of me..."

Hordak's expression eased subtly as he regarded her. She had shared in his suffering under Horde Prime too, for a short time at least. His voice was quiet when he spoke again:

"That was not your doing. It was Prime's." His red gaze fell as his head lowered. "And on the subject of apologies, I believe I owe

you one as well, for the punishments I dealt upon you when you served as my second-in-command, and for…attempting to harm you when I found out…"

He stopped. He turned his head away, squeezing his eyes shut again. His long ears lowered and his hands curled into tight fists at his sides. Catra tensed, watching him warily. But then his red eyes opened again and he looked at her dispassionately.

"when I was…emotionally compromised," he finished finally. "I understand now that it was wrong of me to make you suffer, regardless of your…failures and misdeeds."

Catra's ears lowered onto her head as she avoided his gaze. Folding her arms, she turned away from him slightly. "Yeah, well… We're both sorry. So…let's not talk about that anymore."

"I believe we have said all that we need to on our shared history then," Hordak agreed. He turned his red gaze away from her. "I wish never again to have to speak to you, Catra."

"The feeling's mutual," Catra returned dryly. She glanced back at him. "Watch out for yourself on Beast Island, okay?"

Hordak returned her look. "I will not repeat your sentiment, Catra. I am well aware that you are more than capable of 'watching out' for yourself in any situation."

Moving his gaze behind Catra, he saw Adora and Melog approaching them. The other princesses had joined her as well and were following behind her. As the group neared, he cast his gaze over them: the sea princess, the Plumerian, the child, Princess Scorpia, Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon and the archer. They remained behind Adora as she came to a stop before him.

"Entrapta's not here," Adora informed apologetically, noticing Hordak's sweeping gaze. "I'm sorry." She lowered her head. "She's been…hard to reach."

Hordak's gaze fell. His expression remained empty.

“It is for the best,” he replied simply.

He raised his gaze again to the collected princesses who watched him quietly in return, former enemies regarding one another uneasily.

“I bid you farewell, Princesses,” Hordak announced at last. “For what it is worth, I am grateful for the Rebellion’s victory over Horde Prime. I reiterate my pledge that I will pose no further threat to the kingdoms of Etheria. You may be assured that my days of conquest in the name of the Horde are over. I intend to remain on Beast Island with my brothers for the foreseeable future. You and the rest of Etheria will be troubled by my presence no more.”

The princesses’ expressions and postures seemed to ease.

“Listen, if you ever need help with anything-” Adora started to say.

“I will not,” Hordak interrupted. “I have sufficiently prepared. The only assistance I shall require will be that of my brothers. We do not intend to call on you.”

Catra moved to Adora’s side, stroking Melog’s head as she did so. The magical cat creature nuzzled into her hand.

Adora addressed Hordak again:

“Okay, well…is there…anything I can do for you, as a parting favour?”

Hordak lowered his gaze, seeming to consider this.

“It would be appreciated…,” he uttered hesitantly after a moment, “if you could convey to Entrapta…my desire for her to be…happy.”

Glimmer and Bow’s eyebrows lifted in surprise. Mermista’s face scrunched in distaste. Perfuma smiled uncomfortably. Scorpia’s eyes grew large and wet. Frosta tilted her head to the side in confusion.

Adora's eyes softened at him and she nodded. "I'll tell her you said that."

Hordak seemed to straighten himself. "Thank you, Adora…for your…mercy…and kindness."

A genuine smile appeared on Adora's lips and she reached up with a hand to touch Hordak's shoulder. He remained motionless as her hand came down upon his shoulder, his red eyes never leaving her blue ones.

"It was mercy and kindness repaid," she said gently.

One corner of Hordak's lips slowly rose.

Then Adora removed her hand from his shoulder and stepped back.

Scorpia shyly came forward. "Um, so, you've got everything you need, right, Lord-, er, Hordak, Sir?"

Hordak turned his gaze to his former Force Captain. "I believe so, Princess Scorpia. I am grateful for the ships and supplies you have given me and my brothers."

"Oh, well, I didn't really give them to you since they were old Horde stuff," she chuckled, rubbing the back of her head with a large pincer claw. "They were technically your things since you used to be our leader in the Horde." She laughed awkwardly.

"I am grateful nonetheless for your generosity," Hordak repeated sincerely. His red gaze dropped to the ground. "considering the length of time I occupied your family's kingdom…" His ears lowered as his words trailed off.

Scorpia looked at her former commander hesitantly before tentatively reaching out with a large pincer claw and resting it against the side of his arm. Hordak cast a glance down at her pincer claw on his arm.

“Hey, the Fright Zone may not have been perfect,” she said with a smile, “but it was home for me and lots of others who grew up there. So, no grudges here. And I hope things work out for you on Beast Island.”

Behind Scorpia, Mermista rolled her eyes sideways and muttered to herself: “That makes one of us, I guess.”

The scorpion princess made to move forward, raising her burly arms instinctively to embrace Hordak, but then she paused, looking at him uncertainly. It occurred to her that she’d never hugged Hordak before. He had been their leader, never one for hugs. She’d never even been this close to him before, she realised.

He looked down at her open arms. His ears twitched. Then slowly, he lifted his arms as well, mirroring her.

Before he could even move, a delighted Scorpia threw herself at him, encompassing him in her thick arms as she pulled him into a tight hug. Taken by surprise, Hordak stiffened in her crushing hold, eyes enlarging and ears shooting up.

With a final squeeze, she released him. A stunned Hordak hastened to recompose himself into a dignified position, pushing back strands of blue hair that had fallen into his face.

“I am…humbled by your generosity of heart, Princess,” he managed to say after recovering himself.

Scorpia smiled kindly at him, but then her smile began to fall. “I think Entrapta’s really going to miss you.”

Hordak stilled at her words, then promptly turned away from her and the other princesses.

“I am leaving now,” he announced abruptly.

The princesses watched as the former Horde warlord made his way toward the waiting ships on the water. His clone brothers had

finished loading the supplies and were now boarding the ships. As Hordak approached them, his brothers bowed their heads respectfully. He joined a group of them as they headed up the ramp leading onto the largest of the ships.

Soon, the last of the Horde clones had boarded the ships, and from the shore, the princesses watched them set sail out to sea. The Horde fleet glowed red in the rays of the setting sun as they disappeared into the horizon.

"Well, guess that's the last we'll see of Hordak," Frosta remarked to her fellow princesses.

"Kinda hard to believe," Glimmer thought aloud, "after decades of him trying to take over Etheria and the Rebellion fighting his Horde, this is how he goes: sailing off to a remote island."

"A **dangerous** remote island," Bow reminded. "Beast Island's a living death trap." He shared an uneasy look with Adora. "It's a miracle Adora, I, your father and Entrapta made it out of there alive." He looked out to the sea again, frowning. "I wouldn't want to go back there again, even with better preparation."

A heavy silence descended upon the princesses as they looked out to the sea again. The fleet of ships were little more than dots in the distance now.

Catra turned away from the group, making her way up the beach to the old Horde skiffs they had parked by some large rocks. Melog mewled inquisitively at her and followed. The princesses turned as they noticed her departing.

"Got somewhere I need to go," she announced.

Adora jogged to catch up beside her. "I'm coming with you. Where to?"

Catra kept her gaze ahead. "Dryl."

Chapter End Notes

There's a couple of things about the final season of the show that never quite satisfied me. Apologies if this comes off as a bit of a rant.

Firstly, the onus placed on Entrapta to make more of an effort to get on with the other Princesses and make up for her past with the Horde. This was particularly evident in the second episode of Season 5 'Launch' where Entrapta was forced to explain herself to the other Princesses after an angry outburst from them during a mission. I had very mixed feelings on this episode. On the one hand, Entrapta was given some strong character development and it was nice to see some meaningful representation of autism on screen (even if it was not explicitly named as such). But on the other hand, we witnessed a sadly realistic portrayal of what often happens to autistic people in terms of miscommunication. I couldn't help but feel uneasy as Entrapta was forced to admit she had difficulties with understanding people and subsequently had to prove her desire to help by throwing herself back out onto the field to get information that would help save Glimmer. And she still had to have her hair pulled and be called a 'weirdo' by Mermista (in addition to being leashed by Perfuma earlier). It all just felt...rather insulting and one-sided to me.

Entrapta had to shoulder the responsibility for adjusting herself to fit in with the other Princesses' demands and communicate in ways they would understand and accept. She was made to act and speak in ways unnatural to her in order to be accepted by the other Princesses. Seeing her slapping herself with her own hair and telling herself to "Focus" struck me as a clear sign of how she was making herself behave in an abnormal and uncomfortable way to help her 'friends'. It just re-emphasized how difficult it was for Entrapta to fit in with the other Princesses. And there was nothing from the Princesses' end on acknowleding how Entrapta had felt abandoned by them which led to her joining the Horde before. They made no attempt to understand her and only included her in the mission because of her potential usefulness. Even though the episode ended with her finally

being accepted by the Princesses, I got the distinct impression that she was still very much apart from them. I have the feeling that she and Hordak were always intended to be separate from the Princesses.

Secondly, how Hordak's suffering was never really acknowledged by anyone. Neither Glimmer nor Catra mentioned anything about Hordak after escaping from Horde Prime. There was no recognition of the horror of Hordak's reconditioning and purification and his plight as a slave. His pain and trauma were ignored in favour of Catra's. Entrapta was the only one who ever gave any thought to finding him. And all that was ever said in reference to the end of Season 4 between Catra and Hordak was: "You don't like me." There was just no attention devoted to Catra and Hordak's final fallout in the Season 4 finale, no recognition from Catra of how she had wronged and hurt Hordak. That was something I tried to address in this chapter.

Next update, Adora and Catra head for Dryl!

What the Heart Wants – Part 6

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora discover shocking news at Dryl. And a surprise awaits Hordak as he heads for Beast Island.

Chapter Notes

> A big thank you to everyone who has shown interest in this fic, particularly the thoughtful commenters who have given me things to think about. I'm glad that this post-canon fic seems to be well-received so far. Just hope that readers won't find my final direction disagreeable. I'm not sure how you'll all take it to be honest.
>
> Anyway, prepare yourselves for one or two surprises in this chapter! And remember to let me know your reactions and thoughts afterwards! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dryl was peaceful when Adora, Catra and Melog arrived at the mountain kingdom's gates. Passing through its mechanical town and streets on their old Horde skiff, they finally arrived at the entrance to the Crypto Castle. Alighting from the skiff, they approached the castle's enormous metal doors and Catra pressed a call button on a pad beside them. She stepped back to stand with Adora and Melog as they waited for a response.

After a few moments, without warning, the tall doors slid open, revealing a dark and silent interior. Adora and Catra glanced at one another warily as they peered into the dark entranceway of the Crypto Castle.

"Err, is it normally this quiet when you come here?" Adora asked uncertainly.

Catra's eyebrows lowered in a frown. "No, there's normally more bots moving around." She began to walk into the castle, looking around. "Where have they all gone?"

Adora and Melog trailed behind Catra as they entered the castle. The front doors slid shut behind them, and they found themselves standing in a dimly-lit, empty and tunnel-like corridor running horizontally to them. On the dark purple metal walls, framed pictures of large-eyed creatures hung.

"This place hasn't changed much," Adora remarked as she looked at the odd framed animal pictures.

Catra was looking both ways along the corridor when the sound of metal clanking caught her, Adora's and Melog's attentions. Their heads turned left to see a bright red light shining out from the corridor's shadows. They tensed as a large round shape on three stilt-like legs moved toward them. It emerged from the shadows to reveal a familiar spherical, tri-pedal Horde drone.

"Oh, er, hi, Emily," Catra greeted, fur and tail relaxing again.

The sentient Horde drone beeped in acknowledgement.

Catra stepped toward her. "We need to see Entrapta. Can you take us to her?"

The drone beeped again before turning around and trundling away. Catra and Adora looked at one another and shrugged, then proceeded to follow the drone down the castle's dark corridors.

After several turns, they finally arrived at the doors to Entrapta's main lab which parted for them. Following Emily inside, they were surprised to find an eerily empty space. The large lab, that had once housed piles of metal junk and scrap and rows of hanging robot bodies, had been cleared. Only some empty work tables and the large computer screens at the back of the lab remained.

"Err, doesn't Entrapta usually keep more stuff in here?" Adora asked uncertainly, scanning the large empty surroundings.

Catra's eyes narrowed. "Something's not right."

Emily made her way over to the largest computer screen and stopped beside it, turning to face Adora, Catra and Melog again.

"Emily, what's going on?" Catra asked cautiously. "Where's Entrapta?"

Suddenly, the large computer screen switched on, causing Adora, Catra and Melog to look up at it. They stared in surprise as a large video image of Entrapta appeared on the screen. The Dryl Princess smiled brightly at them from the video screen and waved with hair hands formed from her pigtails. She began to speak:

"Princesses of Etheria and all allies…my friends…I've recorded this message to inform you of an important decision I've made." Entrapta smiled sweetly on the screen. "I am stepping down from rulership and henceforth will no longer be serving as the Princess of Dryl."

Catra and Adora's faces dropped.

"**What?**" they exclaimed simultaneously.

"And in my absence," Entrapta happily continued, "I have elected **Catra** to be my successor as the new Princess of Dryl!"

Catra and Adora's mouths fell open, but no words came out.

On the screen, Entrapta's smile faded as her expression sobered.

"I have come to this decision for personal reasons and after careful consideration." She stared at the camera seriously now. "I hope you will accept it. Upon self-reflection, I realise that I am no longer able to fulfil the role of princess. If I am being entirely honest, I've never really been suited for it. Being a leader of people has never been my forte. The truth is, my heart has always been elsewhere, in science and knowledge and discovery. So, it seems only logical now that I should step down and give way to someone more fitting for the role."

Catra, wide-eyed, managed to stutter: “She’s-she’s kidding…”

Entrapta clearly was not:

“By the time you see this message, I will no longer be in Dryl, and I do not intend to return. But rest assured that I will be safe and well. I have made all the necessary preparations and left instructions for Catra’s ascension to the throne of Dryl.”

A stunned Adora glanced at Catra wordlessly, then back up at Entrapta’s video recording.

Entrapta’s eyes softened and she smiled faintly.

“I am confident that you will be a competent and capable princess, Catra, and that Dryl will prosper and be safe under your leadership. I trust you to look after my kingdom better than I did. Consider this your second chance to do things better. I have already forgiven you for the past. I hope you’ll be able to do the same for yourself.”

Tears were forming at the edges of Catra’s heterochromatic eyes as she stared up frozenly at Entrapta’s recorded visage.

“Adora, Bow and Glimmer,” Entrapta addressed sombrely, “I appreciate that you didn’t forget about me after you left me behind in the Fright Zone, and the efforts you made in trying to rescue me, first from the Horde, and then from Beast Island. It was nice to know that you were my friends after all. I’ve never been good at friendship, but you and the princesses accepted me, so thank you for that. And the same goes to the other princesses: Mermista, Perfuma, Frosta and Scorpia too.”

Entrapta smiled again.

“Scorpia, please take care of Emily. I’m glad to have made friends with you in the Horde and I’ll miss you.”

A strand of her lilac hair rose to her eye and rubbed at a manifesting tear. She sniffled.

“You’ve all been my friends and I’m proud to have been a member of the Princess Alliance and Rebellion. Thank you for accepting me back after I worked with the Horde. I’m glad to have helped you all against Horde Prime. I wish you all joy and happiness. And may the Alliance remain strong and united in friendship. Good bye and good luck, my friends. I’ll never forget you.”

Entrapta’s tearful, but smiling face disappeared as the recording finished. Catra and Adora continued to stare wordlessly up at the blank computer screen for several more moments.

Catra’s arms hung limp at her sides. Her gaze descended to the floor.

“What has she done?” the former Force Captain and Horde co-commander murmured.

Without warning, her knees gave way and she collapsed in a heap on the floor. Adora and Melog were at her sides immediately, Adora kneeling down and catching her partner in her arms.

Emily looked on as the two young princesses sat holding one another.

“What has she done?” Catra repeated, voice cracking as she pressed herself into Adora’s embrace, tears forming at the corners of her tightly shut eyes.

Adora could only stroke her partner’s hair soothingly as she shook in her arms. The avatar of She-Ra looked up sadly again to the blank screen where they had seen Entrapta for the last time.

“I think she’s really gone this time,” she whispered.

Hordak felt drained, emotionally and physically. He had left behind civilised Etheria and was now on his way to Beast Island on an old Horde ship. A number of his brothers, enough to form a small army, had followed him into his self-imposed exile and looked to

him for guidance and leadership. And he had left behind Entrapta…

Silently, as he walked toward his cabin below deck, his heart was heavier in his chest as he thought of her. He'd pushed her away and left her behind…again…Guilt, regret and despair rose within him. He brought his hand to his chest as he felt it tighten, causing his breathing to harshen. His fingers touched the fuchsia First Ones crystal attached there.

With a low growl, he forced the unwelcome feelings down again. He'd left her for her own good, he reminded himself. She was a princess. He was a failed warlord. She had her own kingdom to rule. He had lost his former conquered territories and had nothing left. She was friends with the other princesses, his former enemies. He had no friends, only followers. She was strong and victorious. He was a defect and a failure.

Much as he wished otherwise, they could not remain together. He would only have dragged her down with him in defeat and despair. She did not deserve to suffer alongside him. She deserved better, a better life with better friends...He had to let her go, no matter what she said. She would surely come to understand his decision later.

Hordak reached the door to his private cabin and it slid open. His head hung tiredly as he entered his room. The door slid shut behind him and he made his way toward a simple single bed in the corner of the room. As he approached it, he began to undress, peeling off his long black sleeves from his lean, but defined arms. Scarred and discoloured skin was exposed. He came to a stop beside the bed and allowed the black sleeves to fall from his grasp and land in a crumpled heap on the floor. Then he lifted his hands to the First Ones crystal holding his black shawl together on his chest and began to unfasten it.

A soft *thump* from behind him caused his ears to perk up suddenly and he stopped what he was doing. He turned around to scan his room, but saw nothing. Remaining motionless, he

listened for further sounds. The soft *thump* came again. He identified its source: a storage crate by the wall to his side. Cautiously, he walked toward it.

Standing over the metal crate, he frowned down at it as another *thump*, louder this time, emanated from it. Cautiously, he laid his hand on the lid, then, with a sudden burst of strength, tore it clean off the top of the crate, exposing its contents.

Within the crate, nestled amongst tools and equipment, was a human-sized purple ball of hair. Its long lilac strands shifted and a female face emerged. Sleepy magenta eyes fluttered open as the lilac ball of hair unravelled.

Before a wide-eyed Hordak, Entrapta slowly rose to sit upright from the crate, stretching her arms and letting out a satisfied moan. Then she looked up at Hordak, a rosy blush colouring her cheeks, and a soft smile spread across her lips.

"Oh…Hi, Hordak…," she greeted timidly, forming a large hand of hair from one of her pigtails to wave at him.

Chapter End Notes

> Simpson17866 and treezoob, you get cookies for guessing Entrapta's whereabouts.
>
> I'd like to say that I have great appreciation for the popular post-canon idea of Hordak and Entrapta eventually learning to get along with the other princesses and integrating into Etherian society after helping to rebuild. This, for me, is an idyllic and inclusive ending for these two that would provide opportunity for past hostilities and issues to be worked through and put aside. But I've come to a different kind of conclusion for them in this fic, one that separates them from the other princesses and sees them deviating into their own path.
>
> In a perfect world, we'd all be able to live alongside one another with inclusiveness, patience, understanding and

forgiveness. But reality is rarely so straightforward, and there are times when it could be argued that, for some, being forced to integrate into a society that, for whatever reason, they do not fit well into the norms of, is too difficult and detrimental for all parties. In this fic, I've entertained the, perhaps controversial, notions that, for Hordak and Entrapta, staying with the other princesses in mainstream civilised Etheria may not be the best outcome for them, and that they might be better off seeking a different and unique path for themselves elsewhere.

Growing apart and moving away from others is a natural and valid development of relationships in life. Not all our friendships and relationships will be long-lasting and we will need to move on from them. Sometimes, learning to recognise when we need to move on from certain people in our lives can be difficult but healthy for us. As we've seen in the show, people should be able to leave abusive relationships and situations that are bad for them. But the reasons for people growing apart can be less dramatic too, such as grown children leaving behind their parents and home to create their own lives (though that doesn't always have to be the case as well! Plenty of grown children still live in their parental home with their folks and have good relationships with them!).

Hordak and Entrapta have always struggled in particular to fit in with the people around them in the show, and the consequences of this have not only been social isolation and lack of friends, but it's also been an issue of vulnerability and safety for them. Because their minds and social skills are so out of sync with others, they've not only struggled to be understood and accepted, but they've even been used and harmed and taken advantage of by others. Catra's manipulation of and harm toward both Entrapta and Hordak are striking examples of how their vulnerabilties have made them targets for physical and psychological harm. To a lesser degree, even the other princesses have been guilty of using Entrapta for her skills and treating her in a lesser and

derogatory manner or just ignoring her for her differences. All this has led me to question how good and fitting it would be for Hordak and Entrapta to remain as part of the Princess Alliance post-canon. It is this consideration that has been the inspiration for this fic.

On Catra as the new Princess of Dryl, after hating the princesses for so long, becoming one of them kind of seemed like poetic comeuppance for her. But seriously, it just seemed fitting for her to be in some kind of leadership role since that was what she assumed in the Horde. It puts her and Adora on more equal footing too in terms of status and responsibility. Dryl, as a formerly Horde-controlled kingdom, seemed ripe for Catra to take over. Entrapta had been away from there for a long time throughout the show, so the idea of a new princess taking over it didn't seem all that far-fetched to me. Does Catra deserve to become a princess? That's a question I leave to you readers to answer for yourselves.

Next chapter, Hordak finds himself in unchartered waters. It's going to be emotional!

What the Heart Wants – Part 7

Chapter Summary

> Whilst bound for Beast Island, Hordak's discovery of an unexpected stowaway on his ship leads to a confrontation he was unprepared for.

Chapter Notes

> You might have noticed a change in the number of chapters. I've had to split this and another chapter into two parts as they ended up being longer than expected. I'm now planning for the next four chapters to be a back and forth between Hordak and Entrapta and Catra's situations. Hope you'll enjoy what's to come!
>
> Emotional warning for this chapter. Strong feelings might result!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hordak’s tall ears twitched as he stared at her stunned.

“Entrapta…,” he managed to utter.

His red eyes, large and round, were fixed intently on her as she sat up from the metal crate by the wall of his cabin that she had been curled within, stretching her arms out with a long moan then bringing them to rest upon the curve of her hips, her cheeks flushing a rich rose colour as she noticed him gaping at her.

“Oh…Hi, Hordak…” She waved at him with a large hair hand formed out of her left pigtail.

He blinked, once, twice. He momentarily wondered if he was dreaming. He’d experienced dreams like this before, involving Entrapta, provoking inappropriate sensations and desires within him…

“What…what are you doing here?” he croaked.

She tilted her head down meekly and her hair curled around her. “Um, hiding in your storage crate?”

“I…see that,” he responded numbly.

Her eyes shifted away nervously then returned to him. “Coz…I stowed away on your ship!” Her pigtails swung up dramatically as her words spilled out.

Hordak stared at her speechless, mouth hanging open. It was several moments before he struggled to find words.

“You…you should not be here!” he declared at last, flustered. “I am turning this ship around and bringing you home!” He turned promptly to exit the room.

Entrapta’s eyes shifted away and her hair formed fidgeting hands.

“Oh, well, that’s going to be a little bit of a problem,” she informed meekly, “seen as I don’t have a home to return to!”

Hordak stopped abruptly in his tracks and turned to look back at her.

“What-What do you mean?” he stuttered. “Dryl is-“

Entrapta shrunk a little, still not bringing her gaze to his. She rubbed the back of her head nervously with a pigtail and held an arm with a gloved hand.

“I sorta, kinda-” There was a pause, then her words tumbled out: “-abdicated from the throne of Dryl and left the kingdom to Catra!”

There was no immediate reaction from Hordak. He simply stood paralysed with wide red eyes.

“**What?**” he rumbled unsteadily after a few frozen moments.

“I gave my title and kingdom to Catra!” Entrapta clarified. “I’m not Princess of Dryl anymore! I’m dethroned like you now! So, I don’t have any place left to go except here with you!” She grinned sheepishly.

Hordak felt his throat constricting.

“You…left your kingdom in the hands of the one who sent you to Beast Island?” he choked, disbelieving. “**Why** would you do that?”

“Catra’s had experience of navigating and running operations in Dryl from the time she oversaw its takeover by the Horde!” Entrapta answered factually. “She’s familiar with its layout and resources and knows how to lead people from her time as the Horde’s second-in-command and co-leader!”

She spread her pigtails and arms out at her sides for emphasis.

“She’s perfectly capable of running a kingdom! If anything, she’s more suited for it than I ever was!”

Hordak was breathing heavily now, his red eyes wide with panic. His ears flicked restlessly.

“She-She spread the Horde forces thin and pushed our soldiers to exhaustion!” he argued desperately. “Then finally lost all our armies in a failed attack on Bright Moon!” His voice lowered into a growl. “She has proven herself inept as a leader!”

“The fact that she’s made mistakes means that she’s more likely to have learnt from them!” Entrapta counter-argued. “Despite being emotionally compromised and motivated by destructive reasoning at the time, she helped you plan and execute an effective takeover of Etheria over the course of a year! That’s no small feat! Her failures don’t make her any less a capable strategist and commander!” Her pigtails rose into the air emphatically. “And now that she’s emotionally stable and supported by others, there’s no reason to think that she would repeat her previous errors!”

Hordak turned away abruptly from Entrapta, shaking his head furiously. His hands squeezed into tight fists at his sides.

"No, this is unacceptable!" he barked angrily. "We must go back! You must reclaim your kingdom and your throne! You cannot leave them in Catra's hands!"

Planting her pigtails on the floor, Entrapta lifted herself out of the metal crate and carried herself over to Hordak. From behind him, she reached gently for his shoulder with a strand of hair.

"Hordak…"

Her voice was soft as she turned him slowly to face her. His face slackened and he stared at her helplessly. Strands of her hair cupped the sides of his face tenderly. He remained still in her hold, offering no resistance as she drew him closer to her.

"It's already done," she said quietly, looking into his wide red eyes. "The laws of Etheria dictate that an abdication cannot be reversed. I've given Dryl to Catra willingly. She wants to make up for her past wrongdoings. She deserves a chance to do so."

Without breaking eye contact, she reached down for Hordak's hands with her own, taking hold of them and squeezing them reassuringly. Her voice remained calm and soothing in tone:

"Leaving Dryl in her care is an opportunity for her to make it up to me for sending me away before. I trust her now to lead and protect Dryl better than I did. I'm confident she'll make a good princess for the kingdom."

Her magenta gaze dropped down to their joined hands.

"I forgave her, Hordak," she said quietly, "not because she deserves it, but because I do."

Hordak's brow creased as he stared at her uncomprehendingly.

"I…do not understand," he uttered.

Entrapta kept her gaze focused down on their linked hands.

“I needed to make peace with her in order to move on,” she explained in a low voice. “On Beast Island, I blamed myself. I thought I was bad at friendship, and that was why everyone left me behind.”

Her brow furrowed as her gaze hardened.

“I’ll never forget what she did to me, to us…” Her eyes rose to Hordak’s, conviction in them. “but I choose not to let her actions hurt me anymore.”

She held Hordak’s gaze captive in her own.

“She was young and spiteful and foolish,” she whispered firmly. “What she did to us is not our fault. We shouldn’t be blaming ourselves. Nor should we waste our energy blaming her.”

Hordak’s eyes broke away from hers as he turned his face away from her, long ears lowering. The corners of his lips sunk down into a snarl, showing his gritted blood red teeth. His clawed fingers curled tightly around hers.

“I…I should have known her better,” he hissed harshly. “I should have known **you** better! I **did** know better!” His voice sharpened as it rose in volume. “You had **earned** my trust! And I knew her to be a **liar**! Yet, like a **fool**, I still took her word and allowed her to convince me that you had **betrayed** me! I did not **think** to question her lie! I should have-”

His words were silenced abruptly as Entrapta’s gloved fingertips rose to his thin black lips, coming to rest upon them. He stared at her, wide-eyed, paralysed, mouth agape as his lips were held still by her touch. She gazed softly into his eyes and shook her head slowly from side to side.

“It was **not** your fault, Hordak,” she said with a stern tenderness. “Her actions were her **own**. And we don’t deserve to **suffer** any more for them.”

Her eyes grew wet and her voice shook:

"Stop **punishing** yourself on her account. She isn't **worth** it."

Her gloved fingers fell from his lips and her small face drew closer to his. A fragile smile spread across her pink lips.

"We deserve to be happy now." Warmth and optimism rose in her voice. "Catra's not important anymore. Let her have Dryl. Let it be her responsibility. Let her take care of it for us."

In that moment, despite her small stature, she was so much stronger than him. Hordak struggled to speak as he stared powerlessly at the indomitable purple-haired woman before him:

"Entrapta…you can't…you can't do this…"

He had meant to sound commanding, but it came out as a frail plea instead.

She took hold of his hands again, stroking his dusky blue skin with her thumbs. The small soft smile remained on her lips.

"I can. And I did," she said calmly.

Her lilac hair strands crawled up his neck and began to caress his sharp cheeks and long ears. Lulled by her touch, his head dropped forward into her smooth lilac strands. He shut his eyes in surrender.

"What have you done? What have you done?" he whispered hoarsely.

Her hands squeezed his.

"I made a choice for myself," she said firmly. "I chose not to let others tell me what was best for me. I chose to trust myself and my own feelings. I chose to believe that you cared for me, and that you were my true friend, despite what you said. I chose not to let myself be left behind again. I chose to go with you."

Without warning, he dragged his hands from hers and dropped to his knees before her, bowing his head. Entrapta blinked down at him in surprise.

"You gave up your kingdom and your throne…for me…," he uttered brokenly. "I am not worth your sacrifice. I have nothing. I **am** nothing…"

She slowly lowered herself to her feet with her hair and brought her gloved hands to his cheeks. Gently, she lifted his face to hers and met his solid red eyes with her magenta ones.

"Not in my eyes, Hordak," she said tenderly, her voice full of sincerity. "From the beginning, you offered me respect, listened to me, understood and valued me where others never did." Her eyes brimmed with tears. "And you **turned against your brother**…" Her voice cracked: "**to save me!**" The tears overflowed from her eyes, streaming down her cheeks. She inhaled a shaky breath. "To me, you're **everything**…," she quivered. "You're my **most important** and **dearest** friend."

Chapter End Notes

I've previously made known my dissatisfaction on Entrapta's forgiveness of Catra (in my previous fic *The Origin of Sin* here). It felt to me like a rushed event that occurred primarily to progress Catra's redemption arc. Whilst it may have presented Entrapta as a kind person who bears no grudges, the ease and speed with which she forgives Catra in Season 5 was somewhat disappointing for her character and seemed an unsatisfying conclusion to one of the show's major emotional plot developments.

I have, however, since had time to further consider Entrapta's perspective on forgiving Catra. There are a few aspects about her that are worth consideration:

1. Entrapta's not good at understanding people – This feature of her has made her more technologically-focused and

inclined to overlook people. It's possible she harboured little resentment toward Catra because she never really gave her any importance in her mind. She had already noticed that Catra was not talking to her anymore before she was sent away in Season 3, so she may not have been so invested in her anymore as a friend, especially when she was spending more time with Hordak anyway. This lack of personal investment and importance placed on Catra as a friend might explain why she initially reacted with confusion to Catra's fear of her when they met again on the ship in Season 5. She simply never really considered the severity and ill-intent of Catra's actions against her because they were unimportant to her. Whilst on Beast Island, she immersed herself in the island's technology and avoided thinking too deeply about people and her own emotions, so she never really thought too hard about Catra and how she had been wronged by her. If there was anyone she spared occasional thoughts for during her time on Beast Island, it would have been Hordak, since he was the friend that she had placed most significance on at the time she was sent away. But Catra was no longer on her radar as a person of importance to think of. This is something that has made Entrapta both vulnerable and impervious to the intentions of others. She might only give space in her thoughts to specific people who hold personal importance to her, and naturally ignore people of less importance.

2. Entrapta's insecurities about being liked by people – In the first season, after her capture by Catra in the Fright Zone, Entrapta demonstrated awareness that people often become frustrated and mad at her ("People usually get mad."). And on Beast Island in Season 4, the words of confusion and resignation that she expresses over her 'failed' friendships ("Everything back there with the princesses and then with… Hordak…was so confusing.", "I'm just not suited for friendship.") are indicative of her belief that she is unliked and unaccepted by others, that she is 'bad' at friendship. So, it seems very possible that she had internalised the blame for

her abandonment by others on herself. She may have been blaming herself for her 'failures' at friendship instead of Catra and others for mistreating her.

3. Entrapta's masking in order to fit in with others – She is always cheerful and eager to help, and uses her tech skills to help others in the hope that they will like her. She says this to the other princesses in episode 2, Season 5: "I thought if I could use tech to help you, you'd like me." She overcompensates for her lack of social and people skills by her eagerness to be helpful to others. Perhaps forgiving Catra was something she logically realised she had to do in order to get on with her and others. It was what a 'good friend' would do when someone said sorry for something. She may have simply been trying to follow expected social behaviours by giving forgiveness after an apology.

Aside from the few words of confusion and resignation that Entrapta expressed over her friendships whilst on Beast Island, we never really got to see how psychologically and emotionally affected she might have been by her unfortunate experiences. And, as far as we know in Season 5, she (or anyone else) was never made aware of Catra's manipulation of Hordak during Season 4. It would have been interesting to see what Entrapta's reaction to that would have been. The scope of the show's final season did not allow for exploration of such things though.

So, why would Entrapta forgive Catra? Because if she could forgive someone who wronged her, then she could forgive herself for her failures too, and move on from blaming herself and others. Forgiveness can be a difficult thing to give to people who have severely hurt you, but it is often done more for a victim's wellbeing than for the one who harmed them or caused them grief.

Next chapter, Catra prepares for change.

What the Heart Wants – Part 8

Chapter Summary

> In the wake of Entrapta's abdication from the throne of Dryl, Catra prepares to become the kingdom's new princess. As she does, she learns more about Entrapta's past. Featuring Baker and Busgirl!

Chapter Notes

> I'm raising the rating of this fic to mature due to some of the adult themes that were implied in the last chapter and which might crop up later.
>
> Thanks so much again to everyone who's been following this fic and for the kudos and supporting comments. I particularly appreciate those who have taken the time to write thoughtful comments. All your words are wonderful to read!
>
> Time to check in with Catra now as she prepares to become a princess!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

This was punishment, Catra thought gloomily to herself.

In a lavender-painted bathroom of the Crypto Castle, she sat, exposed and soaked, ears wilted, amongst mountains of foam and floating bubbles in a large pristine bathtub, a miserable countenance on her drenched face as a pair of sturdy hands scrubbed through her shampoo-coated hair. The hands were those of the longest serving member of the castle staff, Beatrice Baker. Beside the large-bodied woman with mint green hair was the smaller, blue-haired young woman, Busina Girllum. With vigorous hands and a bristled brush, the two female members of castle staff scrubbed and rubbed at the wet hair and body fur of the feline ex-Horde woman.

"I'm usually in the kitchens, but I was Princess Entrapta's personal carer and attendant when I first joined the castle staff," Baker informed cheerily. "I spent a lot of time washing and styling her hair before she gave herself the ability to control it through 'neural implants' as she called it."

"Don't worry, Princess Catra!" Busina happily declared. "Princess Entrapta's last orders to us were to make sure that you were properly prepared to become Dryl's next princess! When we're through, you'll look like a perfect princess!"

Catra groaned inwardly.

"That's what I'm afraid of," she muttered.

A bucketful of bath water was suddenly thrown over her head and she screamed. She coughed and sputtered, then grumbled under her breath as she glowered at Baker and Busina.

"Did Entrapta have to go through all this when she became princess?" she asked with a hint of annoyance.

"Oh, yes," Baker replied without hesitation. "Princess Entrapta was presented before the kingdom when she came of age. She was only ten." The large woman paused. "Her parents, her real ones, not the robot parents she built later, were gone before she ever knew them. She was left behind to take up Dryl's throne before she could even walk."

Baker's eyes drifted down and her expression grew heavy. "It was a lot for her to take on. Truth be told, she never looked forward to becoming a princess. All she ever wanted to do was stay in her lab doing her science projects." She shook her head subtly. "Being a princess didn't come easy for her. But she learnt to smile in front of people and help where she could."

Her eyes moved away in thought. "Sometimes I think that's why she joined the Horde, and why she's left the princesses now. She was never really a princess at heart. She was…a scientist."

Catra stared at the large woman, absorbed by what she was telling her about Entrapta. Her expression was no longer of annoyance. She was listening keenly now. Busina continued to scrub her back with the bristled bath brush, but had slowed down to listen to Baker as well. She had not been with the castle staff for as long as the older woman and was interested to hear her insight into their former princess too.

"People said she was eccentric and strange," Baker continued with a reminiscent look and tone, "but she was a brilliant inventor. As she grew up, she single-handedly redesigned and improved Dryl's infrastructure and technology. She increased the kingdom's productivity and capacity through her machines. And she created near unlimited power sources for the kingdom from mined First Ones tech." A smile rose on her face. "Dryl was a self-sustaining and successful manufacturing kingdom under her rule."

Catra had turned her body to the side of the bathtub to watch Baker.

"That's…pretty impressive," she commented wistfully.

Her thoughts returned to her days in the Fright Zone, when she had observed how quickly Entrapta had gained Hordak's favour and trust through her technological prowess. She felt an old pang of jealousy rise within her again. Entrapta could make anything possible through her technological expertise. Her mind was unmatched and had made her a wanted ally by many, including the princesses. Catra had envied her as she rose in Hordak's favour. She could not hope to match her mental abilities or impress others as much. That was why she had begun to distance herself from her, why she had stopped talking to her.

Now the feline ex-Horde woman found herself glumly wondering again: how could she hope to live up to Entrapta's unattainable reputation? How could she do as much as her as the Princess of Dryl?

“Yes. Dryl was developed, prosperous and safe…,” Baker agreed. The smile fell from her face. “at least until the Horde took over and we had to evacuate.”

Catra looked down guiltily. Her ears flicked nervously. She had been the one to suggest to Entrapta that she should ‘join’ her kingdom with the Horde, that it would be a beneficial alliance for both territories. Not long after her promotion to be Hordak’s second-in-command, Catra had personally overseen Dryl’s takeover. She recalled her smug satisfaction as she had watched the Horde’s flags being raised around the Crypto Castle.

Baker’s musing voice interrupted her guilt-induced memories:

“Princess Entrapta wasn’t perfect. She made mistakes, a lot of them. But she had a good heart and a good head on her shoulders.” Baker looked back at Catra and smiled again. “Wherever she is now, I hope she’s happy. She deserves to be.”

A weak smile rose on Catra’s lips as well.

“Yeah, she does,” she agreed. “She definitely does.”

A light knocking brought the attentions of the three women to the bathroom door.

“It’s just me,” came a familiar female voice from behind the door.

The door creaked open, and a dull blonde head popped around it, peering into the bathroom. It was Adora.

“Hey, Catra,” the avatar of She-Ra greeted with a grin. “How’s princess prep going?”

Catra glanced back at Baker and Busina, offering them a small smile.

“Fine,” Catra replied simply. “Just fine.”

"Great!" Adora acknowledged with more relief than she had intended. "I was a little worried the bath might be too much for you. I mean I know how you get around water…"

Catra's ears twitched in irritation as she glared at Adora.

Adora smiled sheepishly at her feline partner and cleared her throat. She quickly changed the topic:

"Right, anyway, just to let you know, there's a few people waiting outside that need to talk to you. When you're dressed and ready, it'd be good if you could see them for a few minutes."

Catra's eyebrow raised in curiosity. "Is it urgent?"

"Weeell, not urgent urgent," Adora replied non-specifically, "but you'll want to see them as soon as possible." A small smile crept onto her lips. "Trust me."

Catra looked at her partner questioningly, but offered a simple nod. Adora flashed her another grin before disappearing behind the bathroom door and shutting it.

"There," Baker announced. "You're ready."

Baker and Busina stepped back from Catra.

In the large dressing room that she stood in, her blue and yellow eyes fell upon a tall oval mirror in front of her. Wordlessly, she stared at her unfamiliar reflection.

Her straightened brown hair was smooth and shiny. She wore a shape-enhancing maroon top and burgundy leggings. Long grey fingerless gloves and foot bindings emphasized the length of her arms and legs. Double short crimson capes hung regally from her shoulders and waist to cover her back. The crest of Dryl, an eight-point star within a cogwheel, stood out prominently on her chest.

Somehow, the new garments imbued her with height, wisdom and radiance. They made her…royal.

"You look absolutely stunning!" Busina declared proudly with a clap of her hands. "Told you we'd make a perfect princess out of you!"

Catra offered a faint smile at her reflection.

"Yeah, you sure did," she acknowledged half-heartedly.

"Will there be anything else you need, Princess Catra?" Baker asked.

Catra turned her head to look at her two female attendants.

"No," she replied promptly. "You've done a great job, both of you. Thank you."

Baker and Busina bowed.

"Then we'll go fetch Princess Adora for you," Baker informed.

The two women turned toward the dressing room door.

When they had exited the room, Catra returned her heterochromatic gaze to the tall mirror in front of her. Her eyes and ears drooped at her reflection.

She had become the thing she used to hate: a princess.

Shutting her eyes, she sighed heavily.

"It's what Entrapta wanted," she whispered to herself.

It wasn't long before a knock on the dressing room door brought Catra out of her thoughts. Her blue and yellow eyes lifted to her new appearance in the mirror again.

She watched herself take a deep breath.

“Come in,” she responded.

Looking over her reflection’s shoulder, she saw the door opening and Adora stepping in followed by Melog.

“Catra?” Adora called.

In her dark red and grey princess garments, Catra turned to face her partner.

The avatar of She-Ra was dressed in a white suit lined with gold patterning, one shoulder covered by a short red cape that was fastened on her other side by a gold brooch. Her watery blue eyes widened as they focused on Catra. A hand rose to cover her mouth.

Catra frowned, shifting nervously under her partner’s gaze.

“Adora, don’t you dare laugh-” she began to growl.

Adora’s hand dropped from her mouth.

“You…look like a princess,” she exhaled, a smile growing on her lips. “A real princess.”

Melog meowed in agreement from beside her.

Her watery blue eyes glistened with unshed tears. “It suits you.”

Catra dipped her head, feeling her cheeks warming as a blush spread over them.

“Thanks,” she said quietly.

Adora gazed at her with silent pride, her smile broadening. Then her eyes shifted to the dressing room door.

“Are you ready to see the people I mentioned earlier now?” she asked expectantly.

Catra blinked. “Huh? Oh, yeah, sure. Send them in.”

Adora made her way to the door and opened it. Three familiar figures entered.

Catra's eyes widened and her mouth fell open.

Chapter End Notes

Personal headcanon: I imagine there used to be more staff in the Crypto Castle when Entrapta was still a child, but as her bots replaced people, they dwindled until only a skeleton workforce remained, including the three kitchen staff from the first season. Catra would likely change this though, seen as how she probably wouldn't appreciate being served by robots all the time.

I'm fond of the idea of Baker being one of the longest-serving members of the castle staff and having the most insight into Entrapta from her childhood.

Regarding Entrapta's childhood, I've left details about her real parents vague. You can come up with your own theories as to what might have become of them. I had a rather controversial idea in my previous fic *The Origin of Sin* for Entrapta's parentage.

Touching on Catra's jealousy of Entrapta from Season 2 seemed like a natural topic to bring up with Catra now preparing to take Entrapta's role as princess. The brief scene of Entrapta perched on Hordak's throne, talking about integrating First Ones tech into the portal machine, had occurred from Catra's viewpoint as she left the Sanctum, displeased and grumbling as she watched Entrapta taking up more of Hordak's time and attention. Being unable to compete with Entrapta to impress the boss had made Catra extremely envious of her, and I'm inclined to suspect that this jealousy had a role to play in pushing Catra over the edge when she later knocked Entrapta out and sent her away to Beast Island. It was evidently the reason Catra had started to avoid Entrapta before then, when Entrapta told Hordak that

Catra wasn’t talking to her anymore. This was something only implied in the show, but it played an understated role in driving Catra’s increasingly harmful actions in Season 3, along with Shadow Weaver’s abandonment of her.

Next chapter, Hordak and Entrapta’s feelings come to a head!

What the Heart Wants – Part 9

Chapter Summary

On a ship to Beast Island, deeper feelings emerge between Hordak and Entrapta and pledges are made.

Chapter Notes

Happy Valentine's all! This update feels very apt for the day and comes with plenty of love. And if you celebrate Chinese New Year, happy Year of the Ox too!

A note to readers: This chapter is a continuation of Hordak and Entrapta's conversation from part 7. Be warned, **mature** content lies ahead! Nothing really graphic, but definitely goes into adult territory.

Also, something that I wanted to highlight from the last chapter:

"She was never really a princess at heart. She was…a scientist."

Baker's above sentences from the last chapter pretty much sum up Entrapta's personal dilemma and the title of this fic. There's always been a disconnect between Entrapta's passion for science and her position as a princess. The source of much of her social woes came from her attempts to fit in with the other princesses when she did not share their views and priorities, and their expectations of her were always based around her being a princess. At the start, they expected her allegiance to be with them because she was a princess as well; they became frustrated with her because she never behaved like them; and her decision to join the Horde was taken as a betrayal against her fellow princesses.

It occurred to me that Entrapta has always struggled to reconcile her status as a princess and her affinity for science.

> This was one of the ideas that influenced this fic, and it inspired the title which refers to Entrapta's (and Hordak's) true desires and where her (and his) heart truly lies. Thought readers might find this interesting to know.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"You're my **most important** and **dearest** friend."

From his position on the cabin floor, Hordak gaped up at Entrapta, stunned by her words. On his knees before her, his face held up to hers in her gloved hands, he felt his eyes beginning to leak and his voice trembling:

"I do not deserve you…"

Her thumbs stroked his long cheeks.

"Hordak…"

The gentleness with which she spoke his name rendered him mute and still.

"This isn't about what we **deserve**…It's about what we **need**."

Her voice was trembling too as she spoke.

"And I **need** you, Hordak." Her lips rose in a delicate smile. A glistening tear emerged from the corner of her eye and ran down her cheek. "I **need** you in my life. I don't want to **do** anything without you. I don't want to **be** without you."

Her lilac hair rose around him, travelling up his limp arms and encompassing his broad shoulders.

"You're more **important** to me than my kingdom and my throne," she uttered with growing resolve. "You're **worth** more to me than any of the other princesses or any other friend. And I…I…"

Her gloved fingers drifted down to the shining fuchsia First Ones crystal on his chest, touching its inscribed symbols tenderly.

She looked intently into his wide red eyes as she exhaled:

"…I want to stay with you."

Hordak gazed at her mesmerised. His clawed fingers rose instinctively to join hers upon the First Ones crystal on his chest. Her name fell as a whisper from his thin black lips:

"Entrapta…"

Her lilac tresses spread from his shoulders over his back, wrapping him in their soft embrace.

"Take me with you…," she whispered, drawing close enough to his face for him to feel the breath of her words on his lips.

"Take…you…," he echoed mindlessly. His fingers closed around hers over the crystal on his chest.

Her pink lips moved toward his sensitive ear, murmuring with disarming softness:

"I want to be with you…"

"Want…you…," he repeated quietly with a shudder, his shadowed eyelids growing heavy.

Her other hand cupped his angular cheek, searing him with the tenderness of her touch. Her magenta eyes cradled his red ones.

Breathless words drifted from her lips:

"I love you, Hordak…"

His heart seized within his chest. His breathing ceased.

Something in Hordak snapped. All the confusing and tormenting feelings for her that he had pushed down for so long came surging to the surface, bursting from his mouth in two words:

"**Love…you!**"

Before he could process what he was doing, he had closed the gap between them, his face on hers, his lips desperately claiming hers. Still on his knees, with his eyes squeezed shut, he groaned and wept as he encircled her with his long, scarred arms, bringing her against his body like he was reclaiming a lost part of himself.

Then his red eyes snapped open and he jerked back in fright, stumbling backwards as he released Entrapta from his grip. She stood frozen with large, round eyes, staring back at him speechlessly.

Panic struck him. What had he done? He had kissed her! He had actually had the audacity to do such a thing! To initiate intimacy with her! What was he thinking? She had given him permission to do no such thing! How dare he besmirch her! He was not worthy to touch her!

He stuttered: "Entrapta, forgive m-"

He was cut off abruptly when long lilac strands of her hair suddenly shot out toward him, enveloping his limbs and body, and dragged him back into her hungry embrace. Their faces and mouths were smushed inelegantly together again. He tensed, long ears standing erect, red eyes wide open as her lips melded with his.

She wanted him! Oh, how she wanted him! And he wanted her!

Lulled by the firm pressure of her warm lips pressing insistently against his, Hordak settled into her kiss and began to return it with equal force. One was not enough though. He followed with another kiss, then another, smothering her lips and the soft skin around them with continuous, rapid kisses.

"I love you…too…Entrapta!" he panted between frantic kisses. "More than…I ever loved…Prime! More than…anything!"

"Oh, Hordak…," she moaned, eagerly returning his fervid kisses. Her hair tightened around him, binding him to her.

He was spurred on by his own exploding passion and the firm grip of her hair and hands on him. Her rich, musky aroma filled his nasal cavity, kindling a fire within him. Seizing her by the shoulders, he hurriedly trailed his lips down from her mouth to the side of her neck, instinctively locating her pulse point.

"You should…not have come back for me…," he uttered breathlessly, sucking hungrily at her throbbing pulse, "because now…I will never let you go…"

"I don't ever…want you…to let me go…," she sighed blissfully, leaning her head to the side to expose more of her neck to him.

He roamed further down to her chest, kissing feverishly over her heart.

"My princess! My angel! My love!" he gasped.

He reached for her gloved hand and lifted it to his face, dropping his forehead onto the back of her fingers worshipfully.

"You need no kingdom or throne to be my sovereign! You rule my heart!" he declared, voice trembling with emotion.

He pressed his lips enthusiastically to her small gloved fingers.

"I will make you my **queen**! I will **serve** you with every last fibre of my being!" he pledged passionately.

A primal instinct guided him as he raised his head to the curve between her neck and shoulder, covered by her plum-coloured collar, and pressed his nasal cavity into it, nuzzling her. Inhaling her scent deeply, his mouth opened, exposing his scarlet fangs, and he bit into the plum fabric, scraping her skin underneath with his sharp teeth. She shivered and a small gasp of delight escaped her lips.

"I will build you a new **kingdom** on Beast Island to call home!" he growled desperately into the curve of her neck. "And we shall **reign** supreme **together**!"

"**Yes!**" she gasped in a rising pitch, her head tilting back ecstatically. "**Together!**"

He looked up at her reverently.

"My beautiful Entrapta…," he exhaled. "I do not…deserve your affection, your love…"

He brought his hand up behind her to cup the back of her neck and nipped at her plum collar, pulling it down with his teeth to reveal the honey-hued skin of her neck. He proceeded to press his lips tenderly to her bared throat. She moaned in response.

"…but if you see fit to grant it upon me…," he murmured against her warm flesh as his lips located a throbbing jugular vein and his tongue emerged to lick at it, "…I will do everything in my power… to be worthy of it."

As he tasted her neck, her gloved fingers dragged down to his chest, sliding over the fuchsia First Ones crystal and nimbly unfastening it. The black shawl slipped from his broad shoulders, revealing the whole of his vein-scarred arms that held her.

Lilac strands of her hair guided his clawed fingers to her shoulders, where her overall straps stretched to support her generous bosom. He tugged at the taut straps experimentally, then slid both off her shoulders in one smooth simultaneous motion, allowing them to fall to the sides of her waist and her heavy breasts to drop.

He paused to watch as she leaned back to pull her gloves off, entranced by the sight of her hands shedding their coverings. Her dark plum-coloured one-piece collar and sleeves were swiftly removed, dexterous strands of her hair peeling the garment up over her head and from her arms. Warm olive skin was exposed as her arms, shoulders and neck were unsheathed.

With bare hands, she pressed against his chest and slid her fingers up to encircle his neck, drawing him into her embrace. Her naked fingers travelled up the back of his neck and head, tangling

with his crest of midnight blue hair. Gently, she pulled his head down to hers, bringing their foreheads together. The soft tip of her dainty nose made contact with the hard ridge of his nasal cavity. Through heavy eyelids, they gazed into one another's eyes, breathing one another in through parted lips.

"Now and forever, I am **yours**…," he whispered breathlessly against her lips.

"And I'm **yours**…," she whispered back softly.

Closing their eyes, their foreheads connected, they held onto one another. The intimacy of their proximity powered the thundering of their hearts as they absorbed each other's touch and inhaled each other's scent.

Their lips came together again, merging into a deep kiss. Hordak's clawed fingers reached up to the base of Entrapta's pigtails and snapped the hairbands binding them. Freed, her lilac tresses waterfalled down her back. Hordak's long fingers ran through her loose silky strands as they wound around his arms and slid around his body.

As they explored one another through their merged mouths and intertwined hair and bodies, Hordak gently picked Entrapta up in his arms and carried her to his cabin bed. Laying her down carefully on the mattress, he locked eyes with her for a moment, searching for any sign of hesitation from her. Her hair around him only tightened and she drew him down onto her. His mouth found her bare neck and he eagerly sucked and licked and nipped his way down it, leaving his marks in her olive-hued flesh.

Slowly, they undressed one another, baring their imperfect bodies before each other: large and small, hard and soft, withered and full, broken and deficient. With soft kisses and tender strokes, they soothed each other's pains and scars. Differences fell away as their kindred spirits rose to embrace each other. Human and alien, flesh and machine, natural and artificial melded together in harmony.

Within their discarded clothes and tangled limbs, their bodies aligning and hearts synchronising, two flawed souls rejoiced in a union that had been a long time coming, gasping and groaning as they filled and engulfed one another, making each other whole.

Chapter End Notes

Hordak tries to push Entrapta away, check. Entrapta disregards and surprises Hordak, check. Hordak stubbornly attempts to resist Entrapta's advice, but eventually comes to accept her logic, check. Hordak has emerging feelings for Entrapta and becomes weak for her, check. Entrapta 'reprograms' Hordak with the power of her love, check. A beautiful and powerful bond of love and trust is formed between them, check. Hordak finally returns Entrapta's love, check.

Did I miss any important stages in the development of their relationship?

Unlike Adora and Catra and Glimmer and Bow's relationships, Hordak and Entrapta's relationship was never explicitly defined as anything past friendship in canon, though there were plenty of strongly implied signs of a deep emotional bond and attachment between them. And it was the strength of this deep bond that triggered the return of Hordak's memories in S5 and caused him to turn on Horde Prime in the end. If their friendship didn't lead to romance post-canon, I think many a fan would be highly disappointed.

I've read other fics that present Entrapta as the one to take charge and lead Hordak in their relationship, whilst Hordak happily follows her and accepts her help. I wanted them to be equal and balanced in power here though as they were in canon, hence another reason why I chose to have Entrapta step down as a princess. Hordak has lost all his power and empire on Etheria, and now Entrapta has given up her royal position and chosen to join him in exile. So, they're both essentially getting a fresh start on Beast Island now. Without

their former positions of power, they are left to be their own people and are free to live the lives they want, away from the expectations and demands of others on an isolated island.

Despite being very different from one another on the surface, they were always of matching passion and strength when they worked together. Intellectually, ability-wise and in force of personality, they were the same. That's a big part of why their relationship worked so well in canon despite their physical size and species difference. I had that in mind as I wrote this chapter too.

Bringing them together physically was a way of cementing their bond and expressing their repressed feelings for one another. Given Entrapta's more mature portrayal in S5, both in visual design (her overalls pulled up and enhancing her bosom) and in her behaviour (flirting with and acting suggestively towards robots and machines), she definitely seemed like a sexually capable adult woman.

I'm aware of portrayals of autistic people in media often showing them to be non-romantic, non-sexual and non-relationship-inclined. So, from that perspective, I appreciate the idea of Entrapta as an autistic character being capable of love, sexuality and having a meaningful relationship with another. I feel there's a common misconception by many that autistic people are lacking in empathy, are sexually incapable and are unable to truly love others. The truth, I believe, is that, for many autistic folk, their empathy and emotions run much deeper than other people's, and they often don't express these in a typically recognisable way. It may take time for others to get to properly know them and learn their unique ways of showing care for others, but they are not without empathy and ability to love, as with any other human being.

Paradoxically, Hordak and Entrapta may be emotionally repressed and socially awkward characters, but their bond with one another is deep and profound. They're a wonderful

testament to the show’s message that everyone is capable of love and deserves to be loved, no matter how rough or strange they might seem on the outside.

Next chapter, Catra is crowned!

What the Heart Wants – Part 10

Chapter Summary

> As Hordak and Entrapta's relationship enters a new stage, so too does Catra's role on Etheria. Left with the responsibility of ruling Dryl, the one-time Horde Force Captain prepares to embrace a new life as a princess.

Chapter Notes

> After the heat of last chapter, we now return to events in Dryl with Catra.
>
> Catra becoming a princess was an idea I laughed at when first struck by it. After I stopped laughing, I contemplated it further, and then it didn't seem like such a bad idea after all. It filled a few boxes for me: Catra gets some real responsibility post-canon, it fits with her leadership skillset, she gets an opportunity to make up for her past crimes and wronging Entrapta, and it puts her and Adora on more equal footing as recognised princesses.
>
> And that, readers, is how Princess Catra came to be.
>
> Thank you again so much to my commenters and kudos leavers. It's always really nice to hear that my work is being enjoyed.
>
> Note: This chapter continues from part 8.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's eyes widened and her mouth fell open.

"Lonnie? Rogelio? Kyle?" she gasped.

The ex-Horde trio that had once been Adora and Catra's squad mates and served under Catra's command stared back at her from

the dressing room doorway, their wide eyes and open mouths mirroring hers. Their old Horde uniforms were ragged and mud-stained, covered by faded sandy cloaks thrown over their shoulders that were torn at the edges.

"Catra…," Lonnie finally said carefully, her eyes sweeping down to take in her former commander's changed appearance. "Wow, you look…different."

There was silence as the four one-time Horde friends stared wordlessly at each other.

Then Kyle stepped forward and hesitantly spoke up:

"We travelled from the Crimson Waste looking for a new place to live," he explained. "It was tough surviving out there, especially with this little guy to look after."

He glanced back toward Rogelio who cradled the small sleeping form of Imp in his large scaled arms, swaddled in a warm light blue blanket and emitting soft snoring chirps.

Looking back to Catra, Kyle meekly continued: "We heard Dryl was accepting ex-Horde soldiers, so…we were kinda hoping that, maybe, we'd be able to stay here."

Lonnie came forward to stand beside Kyle.

"We didn't mean to intrude on you though," she said quickly. "We didn't realise that you were taking over as princess." She put a hand on Kyle's thin shoulder and began to turn him away with her as if to leave. "We can just leave if you'd rather not have us around..."

"**Wait!**" Catra suddenly called, snapping out her hand to the trio.

They stopped, looking back at her cautiously.

"Don't go," she said in a low voice, ears lowering. "You came to the right place. Dryl's doors are open to any ex-Horde soldiers

that require a home, and that includes all of you. You're more than welcome to stay here in Dryl. In fact, I insist that you do." Her yellow and blue gaze lowered. "It's…the least I can do after treating you all the way I did before…"

Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio stared at her, then at one another, then back to her, speechless.

"You really are different," Lonnie said quietly.

Catra's eyes met hers. "I'm trying to be."

Catra could hear the crowds that had gathered outside for her inauguration ceremony. Her tail swished nervously behind her as she waited in the Crypto Castle's foyer. Next to her, Melog rubbed against her thigh and arm comfortingly. Adora approached, offering her a reassuring smile when she looked at her. Returning her smile tentatively, Catra's hand reached for hers.

Before her fingers could touch Adora's, the sound of approaching footsteps interrupted them. Turning their heads in the direction of the footsteps, Catra and Adora saw the other princesses: Mermista, Perfuma, Frosta, Scorpia, Netossa and Spinerella, coming toward them from the castle's entranceway. They had all come formally dressed in ceremonial wear for Catra's royal inauguration.

"So, you're joining the princess club," Mermista remarked flatly as she and the other princesses came to a stop before Catra and Adora.

Catra's ears flattened as she looked away, crossing her arms.

"It's not what I wanted either, believe me," she said lowly. "And I don't expect any of you to trust or like me."

Mermista brought her hands to rest on her hips, sighing audibly.

“I’m not jumping at the idea of you becoming a princess,” she drawled, “but hey, if that’s what geek princess wanted, then who am I to question who she gives her kingdom away to.”

Perfuma stepped forward to join Mermista, her hands calmly joined in front of her.

“We’ve been on opposite sides in the past,” the Plumerian princess offered in a conciliatory manner, “but it’s time for us all to put aside our old rivalries and to come together now. Etheria’s seen enough fighting.”

“And who knows what else may come from Outer Space in future,” Netossa added seriously from behind Mermista and Perfuma. “We need to be united and ready to face anything together.”

Without warning, Scorpia strode forward and lifted a large red pincer to Catra’s shoulder. Instinctively, Catra dropped her gaze from the scorpion princess’ face, hesitant to look her in the eye. The memories of how she had treated Scorpia when they were in the Horde had not diminished in her mind. But Scorpia only smiled kindly down at her.

“Well, I for one am so proud of you, Catra,” she said sincerely. “You’ve come such a long way from the Horde to be a princess like Adora and me now. And I’m glad to know that Entrapta trusted you enough to take over from her.”

She lifted the top of a pincer to her eye to wipe away a forming tear. “I know you’ll make her proud too.” She sniffed and her voice began to wobble with emotion: “I think you’re going to make a great princess.”

Catra looked up at her former Horde companion as she spoke, tears pricking at the corners of her eyes as well.

“Thanks, Scorpia,” she replied quietly. “Really, thanks.”

“Catra…,” Adora called gently.

The feline woman looked at her partner, raising an eyebrow.

Adora smiled at her and gestured toward the castle doors. "It's time."

From either side of her, Catra felt the eyes of the crowds on her as she walked along a long red carpet. Focusing her gaze forward on the raised platform at the end of the red carpet, she kept her head held high despite the butterflies in her stomach.

She shouldn't have been nervous. This certainly wasn't the first time she had been on display in front of audiences. She had been marched to Hordak's throne in cuffs to face punishment before other Horde soldiers. And she had commanded Horde troops in the Fright Zone and on the battlefield multiple times.

But those times had been different. She had not been concerned with others at those times. She had only been concerned with herself and her goals of defeating the princesses and getting back at Adora. She had not cared if she hurt people.

But now, she cared. She cared about making up for her past mistakes. She cared about helping the ex-Horde people living in Dryl. She cared about doing what Entrapta had wanted of her. And she cared about becoming a better person for Adora.

This time, what she was doing really mattered. It mattered to her and others. This time, she had to do better, for everyone.

She couldn't mess this one up.

Approaching the raised platform, she ascended a set of steps onto it. Queen Glimmer was standing at the centre of the platform. Behind her stood the King Father, Micah, and an attendant carrying a red cushion upon which a crown sat in her hands. The sparkling queen of Bright Moon watched Catra patiently as she walked toward her.

Stopping in front of Glimmer, Catra dropped down onto one knee before her, bowing her head. Glimmer raised a hand and laid it on Catra's head. The young Bright Moon queen began to speak in a loud, clear voice:

"Catra, as the chosen successor to the throne of Dryl, do you pledge to serve the people and defend the kingdom for as long as you are able?"

"I do," Catra answered solemnly without looking up from her kneeling position.

"And do you promise to uphold the values and freedoms of the Princess Alliance?" Glimmer continued. "To be a just and fair and compassionate ruler? Never to cause harm or suffering to your people? And always to protect and promote their welfare and safety?"

"I do," Catra affirmed again.

Glimmer removed her hand from Catra's head. The attendant behind her stepped forward, presenting the crown, a brick red headpiece with gold patterning, resting upon the plump red cushion. Glimmer carefully picked up the brick red and gold-patterned headpiece from the cushion and held it above Catra's bowed head.

"Then with this crown, I declare you Princess Catra of Dryl," she announced, placing the headpiece over Catra's head. It fitted around her face like her old headpiece, but extended backwards to curve around her black ears, making them appear taller.

Now wearing her crown, Catra looked up at Glimmer as she removed her hands.

"Arise, Catra, Princess of Dryl," Glimmer declared, "and serve your people and kingdom faithfully, wisely and courageously."

Catra rose to her feet as cheers erupted from the crowds:

"**Hail, Princess Catra! Hail, Princess Catra!**"

Catra turned to face the cheering crowds with a smile and lifted a hand to wave at them. In the front row, the princesses were clapping, smiles on their faces too. Scorpia was waving a pincer back at her and cheering loudly. Adora, clapping with the other princesses, had tears in her watery blue eyes as she looked up with immense pride at Catra.

Catra inhaled deeply as she looked out across the crowds.

She was a princess now. And she would do whatever it took to be worthy of the name.

Chapter End Notes

I have to admit, I hadn't originally planned to write chapters on Catra's ascension to be Dryl's new princess, been that this is an Entrapta/Hordak-focused fic. But I later thought that I might as well see this plot thread through to its conclusion, so here we are.

The Horde trio aren't usually the first people to come to mind when we think of all the people Catra wronged throughout canon, but they were amongst the many soldiers who were mistreated and worked to exhaustion by Catra during her co-command of the Etherian Horde in S4. I thought it would be good for Catra to have an opportunity to make up for her poor treatment of them as well.

Having Catra and Entrapta essentially switch places with Catra becoming a princess and Entrapta stepping down to pursue her own life was a nice twist to this story. And it served to re-emphasize how status and power aren't everything. Finding what we really want in life is important for being our true selves and happy. If one can achieve that, they'll have power over their own destinies.

Next chapter, Wrong Hordak!

What the Heart Wants – Part 11

Chapter Summary

> Wrong Hordak discovers that his brother has unexpected company.

Chapter Notes

> I'm extending this fic by another two chapters for a two-part bonus epilogue!
>
> Thank you again to everyone who has shown appreciation for this fic! It really does brighten my day!
>
> Warning: Implied nudity.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Wrong Hordak hummed contentedly to himself as he made his way through the lower deck corridor of the old Horde naval command ship, passing cabin doors on either side of him. In his hands, he carried a tray of prepared food and drink: a bowl of mixed fruit, slices of bread and a glass of orange juice.

He slowed as he reached the last cabin door at the end of the corridor, stopping before it. Balancing the tray on one hand, he took a moment to straighten his light blue shirt, then raised his fist to knock lightly on the door. Stepping back, he waited patiently with a smile for the cabin's occupant to come to the door.

A moment passed. Then another. Wrong Hordak raised his fist and knocked again, a little louder. Muffled sounds emanated from the closed cabin door: the creaking of a bed, low cursing, bedsheets being shifted, clothes being pulled on quickly, feet scrambling across the floor. Wrong Hordak's ears twitched at the sounds.

Then suddenly, the cabin door opened a fraction and Hordak peered out at him through slitted red eyes. Wrong Hordak beamed at him.

"Good morning, Brother Hordak!" he greeted jovially. "I have prepared your morning sustenance!" He held up his tray of prepared food and drink.

Hordak's narrow red eyes moved down to the tray of food and drink, then threw a quick glance behind himself back into the room before he gingerly opened his cabin door a little wider. His hair and garments were dishevelled: loose strands of his midnight blue hair fell untidily over his forehead, and his navy blue dress had been haphazardly thrown on. His discoloured, scarred arms were uncovered. Wrong Hordak tilted his head to the side as he stared at him curiously.

"I will take it," Hordak informed in a subdued voice, reaching out with both hands to receive the tray of food. "Thank you, Brother."

Wrong Hordak was passing the tray over to Hordak when a long female moan emerged from somewhere behind Hordak:

"Mmmm…"

Hordak's eyes widened and he froze with the tray in his hands.

Wrong Hordak blinked at him, once, twice.

There was an awkward pause before Wrong Hordak finally asked:

"Brother Hordak, do you…have company?"

Hordak's cheeks and ears had suddenly turned bright red. He growled lowly as his ears tilted in embarrassment.

"It is none of your concern-" he began to grunt.

"Hordak?" came the female voice again.

Wrong Hordak moved his head to the side as he tried to look around Hordak for the source of the voice.

"Brother…I am quite certain I hear another female occupant in your room," he insisted.

Hurriedly, Hordak retreated back into his room as he tried to shut the door with his bare foot. He began to dismiss his brother:

"Good day, Broth-"

Wrong Hordak's green eyes grew large and his ears perked up when, from over Hordak's shoulder, he caught a glimpse of something purple on the bed behind him.

"Entrapta?" Wrong Hordak called out in surprise, instinctively pushing both the door and Hordak aside as he visually confirmed his sighting of her in the room.

She was sitting up in Hordak's bed, long lilac hair loose around her, a blanket pulled up to her bare chest and wrapped around her body.

"Wrong Hordak! Hi!" she called back brightly with a wave of her hair.

Hordak gritted his teeth as he glared angrily at his brother. He moved quickly to Entrapta's side by the bed, depositing the food tray onto a bedside table.

"He does have a name now," he informed stiffly, turning to face his staring brother with displeasure. Folding his scarred arms across his chest, he consciously positioned himself to partially obscure Entrapta from his view. "We refer to him as 'Kadroh'."

"You are correct, Brother Hordak!" 'Kadroh' beamed, oblivious of his brother's displeasure. "I possess a name of my own now! And it is 'Kadroh'!"

“Kadroh!” Entrapta exclaimed, also oblivious of Hordak’s displeasure. Her eyes lit up and her hair puffed up around her. “That’s actually a lot easier than ‘Wrong Hordak’! I like it!”

“I had thought that you would be remaining with the other princesses,” Kadroh said with a confused look. “Are you not needed in your kingdom of Dryl?”

“Nope!” Entrapta declared with a grin. “Dryl’s not my kingdom anymore, so I snuck on board your ship to join you all to Beast Island! Hope you don’t mind!”

Kadroh’s green eyes lit up and a wide grin broke across his lips.

“Not at all!” he exclaimed jubilantly, raising his fists in excitement. “This is a most wonderful surprise! Now we may remain close friends! And Brother Hordak will no longer be lonely!”

Hordak’s cheeks burned red and he brought a hand up to cover his face.

Oblivious of his brother’s embarrassment, Kadroh happily continued:

“Had I known you would be joining us, I would have prepared morning sustenance for you too!” He gave Entrapta an apologetic look.

She waved it off with a hand and a corresponding hair hand. “That’s okay. I brought some tiny food with me!” With a tendril of her loose hair, she reached for the foot of the bed where a purple rucksack and a small purple toolbox sat on the floor. She fished into the rucksack and pulled out a handful of compact wrapped food bars, holding them up to display.

Hordak’s hand had dropped from his face and he now glared impatiently at his brother. He stepped forward toward him.

“We will be fine, Brother,” he gruffly interjected. “Now if you would leave us.” He began to usher Kadroh out.

“I look forward to speaking again with you soon, Entrapta!” Kadroh called, waving as he was led by Hordak to the door.

Entrapta waved back with a hair hand. “Bye, Kadroh!”

As Hordak promptly opened the door for him, Kadroh gave another grin and wave back at Entrapta. A low growl emanated from between Hordak’s clenched teeth.

“Get out!” he snapped impatiently, throwing a clawed finger out to point at the open doorway.

With an unshaken smile still on his face, Kadroh hastily exited. The door was shut loudly immediately after him by a visibly irritated Hordak. He seethed at the closed door for a few moments before releasing a low snort through his nasal cavity. He then turned his attention back to Entrapta on the bed.

“How considerate of him to bring breakfast!” she complimented, her focus on the tray of food Kadroh had brought on the bedside table.

“Yes…considerate,” Hordak repeated in a low tone, his ears lowering as he returned to her side on the bed.

She looked up at him with a smile, but her smile faded when she finally noticed his glum expression.

“Hordak…is everything okay?” she probed.

“Yes, of course,” he replied flatly, not looking at her.

“Are you sure?” She glanced away. Her hair began to curl around her. “If I’ve done something to make you uncomfortable…”

Hordak’s red eyes snapped to her and his large hands were suddenly on her bare shoulders, clutching them. She stared at him in surprise.

“No! You have done nothing wrong!” he insisted. His long ears twitched nervously. “I…merely wish…” His eyes darted away from hers and his cheeks turned red. “…for us to be uninterrupted.”

Chapter End Notes

I’m joining the ‘Wrong Hordak is Kadroh’ bandwagon! He was happily surprised to see Entrapta. Hordak wasn’t so happy to see him being so familiar with her. He’s still an insecure emo bat boy who gets jealous. Can’t blame the poor lovestruck techno bat alien for getting territorial over his queen, now can we?

Regarding the food, I imagine the clones would have to adapt to eating solid foods now that they’re on Etheria. I like the idea of them being into fruit!

There’s more I wanted to say before on Entrapta leaving the princesses in this story:

Entrapta was always an unconventional and unusual princess. She spent her time locked in labs building robots and conducting scientific experiments. Her castle was a maze full of traps and machines. And she was technologically-gifted rather than magically like other princesses on Etheria.

She was always a scientist before a princess. Her heart and place were never really with the other princesses. That was why she defected to the Horde so easily in the first season. She had never fitted in with the other princesses. Though they had invited her to join the Alliance and tried to work with her, they had never truly understood her.

Being misunderstood and mistrusted by the princesses was a source of considerable pain for Entrapta in canon. Her social and communication difficulties combined with her hyper-focused interest in technology led the other princesses to mistakenly assume that she did not care about people and to distrust her.

In this story, the princesses tried to be a friend to Entrapta. They cared for and meant well for her. They accepted her back into the Alliance, included her in their social functions, and expressed concern for her. But the fundamental flaws in their relationship with Entrapta remained: they still didn't really understand her, and her wishes diverged from theirs. They continued to speak to her in ways that were demeaning, tried to lead her to 'fit in' better with them, and expected her ultimately to fall in line with them.

It's a difficult situation when people close to you genuinely care for you and want you to be safe and well, but they don't really understand what it is that you truly want and need. Without meaning to, they may come to be at odds with you and dismissive of your wishes by acting in what they believe is your best interest. Angella and Glimmer's strained mother-daughter relationship was an example of this, and a similar situation has occurred between Entrapta and the princesses in this fic.

They were never on the same wavelength, so having Entrapta realise this and make the choice to leave behind the princesses and pursue her true passions with Hordak felt right for her. It was also a nice reversal of the times she was left behind by the princesses and then Catra in the show. This time, she left them all behind instead.

Next chapter, arrival on Beast Island!

What the Heart Wants – Part 12

Chapter Summary

> Forging a new bond together, Hordak and Entrapta prepare to embrace a new life as they arrive on Beast Island.

Chapter Notes

> Reaching the end of this fic now. The last two chapters after this are going to be epilogue chapters. Thanks again to you readers for joining me throughout this story. All your kudos and comments especially have been greatly appreciated. I hope you'll be satisfied with how things work out for Hordak and Entrapta here. The purpose of this fic was to give them a satisfactory conclusion after all.
>
> **Warning**: implied nudity and mature activities ahead!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Entrapta watched Hordak curiously as he sat hunched before her on the bed, ears flicking and eyes lowered, like a fearful young boy. She reached back for his scarred shoulders with strands of her lilac hair and rubbed them soothingly. He looked back at her tentatively and saw her smiling gently. A reciprocal smile grew on his thin black lips as well.

His gaze fell to a bright red bite mark adorning the spot between her neck and shoulder. He smiled fondly at it, remembering how he had marked her in the heat of their coupling. Taking her small hand in his, he lifted it delicately to his lips.

"I…want you all to myself," he uttered as he turned her hand over to present her palm and planted a soft kiss on the fleshy pad of her thumb. Extending her arm towards him, he followed this with further soft kisses along the length of her arm, working his way up to her shoulder.

She emitted a contented sigh as tendrils of her lilac hair wrapped around the back of his head and snaked under the side slits of his navy blue dress, tangling with his dark blue hair, caressing his lowered ears, and massaging the lean muscles of his scarred body underneath the cloth of his dress appreciatively. An approving growl rumbled from his chest in response.

"Mmm, you're so sweet, Hordak…," she cooed amorously, "and the best lab partner a scientist could have." She cupped his cheek in a hand and he leaned into it contentedly as she lifted his eyes to hers. "You know that, right?"

He gazed up at her adoringly, sliding his hand over her lower back to pull her closer.

"I know that I hold the brightest star of all in my arms," he exhaled, rising to his bite mark between her neck and shoulder and licking it affectionately.

Her lilac hair strands tugged at his lower dress, pulling it upwards. He helped her to undress himself, slipping the long garment over his head in one fluid motion.

Baring his scarred body to her entirely once again, he looked at her with a devious smirk. "Now, where were we before we were interrupted?"

She giggled when he pounced playfully at her neck, nibbling up to her ear and rising above her. The blanket that had been protecting her modesty dropped from her grasp as he leaned over her, gently guiding her down onto the bed with a supportive arm under her back, holding her gaze warmly in his own as he did. She was flushed from her cheeks to her bare chest as she smiled up at him, her magenta eyes sparkling with unspoken love. The sight of her took his breath away.

"My darling Entrapta…," he breathed in wonder.

Her hair curled around him as he descended onto her, capturing her lips in his.

He sucked hungrily at her lips, drawing out her sweetness. Lifting himself from her, he pulled lightly at her lower lip with his teeth, taking care not to graze her. His vivid red eyes remained on her as he extended an arm out to the table where Kadroh's breakfast tray sat. Reaching into a bowl of fruit, he stabbed into a plump strawberry with a claw and brought it above her enticingly. She watched intently as his long tongue emerged from his mouth to lap up the juice of the strawberry that dripped down.

"Hungry?" he asked with a mischievous smirk.

"Famished," she replied with a sensuous lick of her lips.

Taking the head of the strawberry between his thin black lips, he lowered it to her parted full pink ones.

As he dropped the fruit into her mouth, they bit into it together, savouring its flavour on one another's lips. Juice, blood red, dribbled from their merging mouths as they consumed one another.

Horde Prime had lied.

He had never been satisfied, never been content, never been at peace…

…never been happy.

The realisation struck Hordak as he stood on the deck of his docked ship, gazing out over the railing at his clone brothers below as they deboarded their ships and unloaded their supplies onto the crimson shores of Beast Island.

Not only had their exalted brother not been all-knowing and all-powerful as he had claimed, he had never truly known peace either.

Oh, he had preached it to all his brothers and his galactic empire, his goal to bring peace to all, to free all beings from pain and suffering. It had been in the galactic Horde's mantra: 'All beings must suffer to become pure.'

But Prime himself had not been pure. He had not been free of malice and rage and insanity. He had been willing, after all, to embrace planet-wide destruction in the end.

He had been flawed…imperfect.

He had always wanted more: more followers, more worlds, more control, more power. He had sought to spread his 'peace and order' across the universe, to increase his dominion and power over all things.

Under the grandeur of the great emperor of the known universe, Prime had been insecure, unassured…afraid. He had needed the power of conquered worlds to spread his control, and the absolute devotion and glorification of armies to raise him above all life, to worship him as a god.

A fallible god.

Entrapta's excited voice cut through Hordak's ruminations.

"This is going to be so much fun!" she squealed from beside him, twirling happily on her hair. "We're going to learn all of Beast Island's secrets!" She cackled gleefully. "The Heart of Etheria was just the tip of the iceberg! There's so much more the First Ones left behind here!"

She looked up at Hordak with a wide grin. "With you and your army of brothers, I'll be able to discover EVERYTHING! AHAHAHAHAHAHA!" She threw her arms out dramatically as she exuberantly screeched the last word and cackled manically.

A low chuckle escaped from Hordak as he regarded her fondly, a smirk on his thin black lips.

Prime would not have tolerated this. He would never have seen the value of working with another. He would never have allowed a partner at his side.

Believing that he could stand beside his big brother had been a foolish hope. Hordak knew that now. Prime would never have accepted anyone as his equal. He would never have shared power with any other being.

But Hordak had. He had accepted help from others. He had trusted others. And he stood now with his equal at his side, his partner, his beloved Entrapta.

That was what separated him from Horde Prime: trust and companionship. He had learnt to rely on and trust others. Prime had trusted no-one: he had only controlled others, his followers existing only to obey and serve him faithfully.

Lowering himself onto a knee before her, Hordak took hold of Entrapta's gloved hand with courtly grace and clasped it between his large palms.

"Entrapta, I will make up for my past mistakes," he promised earnestly. "Never again will I doubt or abandon you. Never again will I fail you. I shall strive to be worthy of your trust and affection."

He clasped her small hand more tightly between his palms. "I will conquer this land for you, my Queen. Beast Island will be your new kingdom to rule."

A warm smile grew on her lips at him. Her lilac hair tendrils slid over his hands.

"**Our** kingdom, my King," she corrected affectionately. "It'll be **ours**."

He brought her hand up to his lips and pressed a soft kiss to her fingers.

“Yes. Ours,” he exhaled, gazing adoringly into her sparkling magenta eyes.

She encompassed him in strands of lilac hair and pulled herself against him in a squeezing hug.

“Oh, Hordak, I’m so happy to be here with you now!” she bubbled joyfully, contentedly pressing and rubbing her cheek into his broad chest. “Just the two of us, your brothers and this whole island to ourselves! It’s going to be A-MA-ZING!”

He wrapped his long, black-sleeved arms around her, returning her embrace.

“I am…happy…you are here with me as well,” he returned tentatively, a soft smile rising on his lips. “There is no-one else I would wish to be with. You are the only one I would have as my partner, Entrapta.”

Tenderly, he ran his clawed fingers through one of her pigtails. “Together, we are capable of anything.”

Entrapta’s sparkling magenta eyes rose to his. Her lips lifted in a gentle smile.

“Together, we’re perfect,” she replied with warm confidence.

He tightened his hold around her a little more, his smile reflecting hers.

At that moment, the former Lord of the Fright Zone and would-be King of Beast Island resolved to be different from his creator.

Unlike Horde Prime, he would stand with an equal at his side. He would share his failures and victories and weaknesses and strengths with his trusted and beloved partner. With her, he would know contentment and happiness.

Here, on Beast Island, he would build his own kingdom with his queen by his side.

Here, they would reign supreme over the beasts and technological monsters of the First Ones.

Here, in their new home, they would be free to be imperfect and happy together.

And nothing would ever tear them apart again.

Rising to his feet, Hordak turned his red gaze out to the crimson shore of Beast Island and its dark jungle beyond. He looked back down at Entrapta with a debonair smile and held his hand out to her.

"May I escort you to our new home, my Queen?" he asked genteelly.

With dazzling magenta eyes and a brilliant smile, Entrapta reached for his offered hand. "I'd like that, my King."

She placed her hand into his, accompanied by tendrils of her hair wrapping around his long arm. Hand in hand, they approached the top of the ship's boarding ramp.

On the beach below, the Horde clones stopped to bow in respect as their King and Queen descended.

Chapter End Notes

> Presenting Hordak and Entrapta, King and Queen to be of Beast Island! The princesses and Catra can rule civilised Etheria. Beast Island is going to be Hordak and Entrapta's little paradise and sanctuary.
>
> On Horde Prime, his driving motivations and flaws were never delved into too deeply in canon, but I considered how abuse often begins and it occurred to me that abusers are likely often people who are deeply unhappy or insecure with themselves. They take out their fears and unhappiness on others and try to control the people around them, to keep at

bay their sense of helplessness or inferiority, and to assure themselves that they are in control and powerful.

Having Hordak realise that Horde Prime was never truly content and at peace and a flawed being was significant. He, like all the clones, was programmed to see Prime as a perfect, flawless God without weaknesses. It was part of the reason why Hordak saw himself as a failure and was ashamed of his physical defects, the fact that he was cast out for being imperfect. So, realising that Prime had in fact been imperfect too because of his instability and unsatiable quest for more power and control was important for Hordak.

But there's a crucial difference between Hordak and Horde Prime in the form of accepting help from and trusting others. For all of Hordak's flaws and wrongs, he learnt to rely on others for help, and eventually came to trust Entrapta, and for a while Catra too. He was willing to treat Entrapta and Catra after as partners and equals. He shared power with them each for a while. And though not in equal command and complete trust, he also relied on Shadow Weaver and gave her position and power within the Etherian Horde as well as control of the Black Garnet. He survived on Etheria for so many years by accepting help from others.

In contrast, Horde Prime controlled others. He had no need of trust since he could control bodies and minds to the extent of occupying them as vessels. And he did not have to accept help from others because he had his own army of clones to do his bidding. Unlike Hordak, he never had a need for companionship from others. Others existed simply to serve him. He never would have seen another as an equal. He had made himself all-powerful with no need of companions.

Next, Epilogue – Part 1!

Epilogue – Part 1

Chapter Summary

> Having settled on Beast Island, Entrapta returns with Hordak to the First Ones temple at the centre of the island.

Chapter Notes

> Thank you so much to everyone who has shown their appreciation for this fic. It's wonderful to see the hits, kudos and comments this fic has received. When I started writing this, I wasn't sure how Entrapta and Hordak fans would react to it. I took a bit of a risk going down the path of Hordak banishing himself to Beast Island and living apart from the rest of Etheria. It's a less conciliatory outcome for him and moves away from the idea of him integrating with the princesses and the rest of Etheria. He's no longer an active enemy of the princesses and Etheria, but he's also not able to live alongside them and be accepted within mainstream Etherian society. I see him now as taking after Entrapta in how he has relegated himself to a neutral position that's neither against nor ally to the Princess Alliance. He and Entrapta are just carving their own path on Beast Island away from others.
>
> Some time has passed since Hordak and Entrapta's arrival on the island; I imagine a few months, enough time to have settled, developed survival strategies, become familiar with some of the island's 'wildlife' and scavenged some tech.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Large bodies moved through the dense jungle of Beast Island, shaking the dark trees as they passed them. As they approached, birds took to the air from the tree branches, bugs and reptiles dived back into their burrows in the ground, and a group of pookas dispersed and fled.

From the dark trees, giant creatures emerged: monstrous techno-organic bugs and reptiles. There were several of them, moving together: gigantic beetles, ants, lizards and serpents in a myriad of colours. Their eyes glowed in blues, pinks, purples and reds. Reins were attached to their heads, held by humanoid riders with white hair, white faces and lime green eyes: Horde clones in dark grey armour with purple highlights. They rode on saddles upon the giant beasts' heads. And on the sides of all the clones' heads, metal chips were attached to their temples, blinking with red lights as they emitted signals to receiving chips on the giant beasts' heads.

At the front of the group of giant techno-organic beasts was a white dragon with dark blue wings and crimson eyes. On its long, elegant head rode a dark blue-haired Horde clone with burning red eyes: Hordak. He was encased in new armour that resembled his old exoskeletal one. The navy blue and silver plates moulded around his body with dark purple highlights gave him a sleek but powerful appearance. Silver-framed wings with navy blue artificial membranes sat neatly folded on his back. No longer did he wear the red-winged Horde emblem. Instead, his diamond-shaped fuchsia First Ones-inscribed crystal was set into the centre of his navy blue chest plate, surrounded by an eight-point purple star design.

Riding beside him within her large fuchsia mechanical beast was Entrapta, sitting in the tinted glass dome-protected cockpit of the mechanoid. She was dressed in a dark purple jumpsuit with red highlights, a blue diamond-shaped First Ones crystal sitting within an eight-point purple star design on the front of her suit.

Together, the former Horde warlord of Etheria and the former Princess of Dryl led their band of Horde clones on giant techno-organic beasts through the dark trees, sending the island's wildlife scattering in all directions. They slowed when they arrived at a tall obelisk structure amongst overgrown trees.

Entrapta's mechanical beast came to a stop and she brought a finger to her right ear, pressing on a small device hidden within it.

A low beep sounded as a communication line was opened.

“This is it! The First Ones temple!” she announced brightly, staring up at the tall obelisk structure with a wide grin.

From their own earpiece communicator devices, Hordak and the other Horde clones heard her announcement. Hordak pulled on his dragon’s reins, bringing the winged beast to a stop beside Entrapta’s mechanoid beast. Behind them, the other clones brought their beasts to a halt as well. Hordak lifted a clawed finger to his tall ear, pressing his earpiece device.

“Brothers, we have arrived at our destination,” he informed. “Activate your signal blockers and remain on guard whilst our queen and I investigate.”

“Yes, Brother Hordak!” the clones chorused, raising their hands to their earpiece devices and pressing on them to fulfil their leading brother’s command.

Hordak pressed his earpiece device again, turning on the in-built signal blocker that he and Entrapta had designed: a counter-signal emitted into the wearer’s ear to neutralize the island’s mind-affecting signal. Within her mechanical beast, Entrapta did the same.

With practised ease, Hordak tugged on his dragon’s reins and knocked his long silver-lined navy blue boots against the white beast’s hide. This prompted it to lower its long head to the ground, allowing him to dismount from it. A dark purple-lined navy blue skirt dropped down to his knees as he slid off the beast’s head. Side slits in the skirt revealed his navy blue-clad thighs above the long silver and navy blue boots.

Standing on the ground, Hordak reached out and patted his dragon on the snout in thanks before leaving it to make his way toward the fuchsia mechanical beast. As he drew near, the mechanoid’s large metal jaws opened, revealing a beaming Entrapta within. At the sight of her, a smile rose on Hordak’s face.

“My Queen,” he greeted as he held his hand up to her in offer of assistance.

Using strands of her long lilac hair, she lowered herself down from the mechanoid’s jaws toward the ground, taking hold of Hordak’s offered hand as she stepped out of her mechanical beast and allowing him to help her to the ground.

“My King,” she greeted back as she looked up at him with bright magenta eyes.

For a moment, as they stood together, hand in hand, they held one another’s gazes, fond smiles on their lips.

Then Entrapta tugged at his hand excitedly.

“C’mon, there’s something inside you **need** to see!” she exclaimed, pulling him as she pointed up to the tall obelisk structure before them.

With a smile, Hordak bent down and scooped her up in his armoured arms. She giggled as he literally swept her off her feet. From his back, the mechanical silver and dark blue wings extended and a rocket thruster on his lower back roared to life.

Carrying Entrapta in his arms, Hordak took flight, resembling a giant bat as he soared up and whisked them both towards a narrow bridgeway that led into the obelisk-shaped ancient First Ones temple. As he landed gracefully on the bridgeway, he carefully set Entrapta down on her feet. His mechanical wings folded behind him again.

With an outstretched hand and strands of her long lilac hair, she took hold of his large hand again and pulled him behind her as she took off down the bridgeway. He voiced no complaint as they ran together, hands joined. He only smiled contentedly at her obvious excitement and the sight of her trailing lilac hair as it flowed behind her in the wind.

Slowing down, they approached what at first glance looked like nothing more than a solid wall, but, upon closer inspection, was revealed to be a camouflaged curtain. With a sweep of her lilac pigtail, Entrapta drew the curtain away to reveal a sealed metal doorway. With the press of a large button to the side, the doorway was opened. A metal door slid upwards, granting them entry to a shadowed corridor.

"Fascinating," Hordak commented.

"Wait 'til you see what's inside!" Entrapta squealed excitedly, racing into the shadowed corridor.

Raising his right arm, the plates of Hordak's armour shifted and reconfigured themselves into a new weapon: a large silver arm-mounted cannon lit by purple power lines. Armed, he proceeded into the dark corridor after Entrapta.

Chapter End Notes

> So, Hordak and Entrapta have developed a way to tame the beasts of Beast Island using some kind of modified chipping technology, and they've created portable tech to protect themselves from the island's signal too.
>
> If she ever returned to Beast Island, I imagine Entrapta would want to find the First Ones temple where she discovered the Heart of Etheria again, and naturally she'd bring Hordak along too. She mentioned in S4 how everything she ever wanted to know about the First Ones was there. I'm willing to bet that the Heart of Etheria wasn't the only important information stored on that ancient supercomputer.
>
> Beast Island, justifiably, has a bad rep for being a deadly island of no return. After all, it's where Hordak used to banish traitors (Shadow Weaver and Catra) and enemies (King Micah presumably, although we're can't say for certain who exactly banished him there). And we saw from the S4 'Beast Island'

episode how the island consumes victims, both in mind and body.

Entrapta herself declared Beast Island to be a ‘paradise’ though, and she was reluctant to leave it. It was a treasure trove of First Ones tech for her. So, I would hazard a guess that Hordak and Entrapta are perhaps the only two people on Etheria that could happily survive on Beast Island. They’d figure out a way to protect themselves from the signal. And there’s enough junk and data there for them to explore and use. I think they could be happily occupied there for some time.

On Hordak’s new armour, I imagine he and Entrapta built it together. The addition of wings seemed fitting for Hordak given the wings on the Horde emblem. I kind of took design inspiration from David Xanatos in the 90s Gargoyles cartoon. For those old enough, you might recall his red Goliath-based armour. It had retractable wings and a jet booster to propel him into the air. So, you can consider Hordak’s Beast Island armour here a creative nod to Xanatos!

Next, the final update: Epilogue - Part 2!

Epilogue – Part 2

Chapter Summary

> Within the First Ones temple on Beast Island, Hordak and Entrapta make a discovery that could impact on their future.

Chapter Notes

> Finally reached the end of this emotionally-charged story. It's been fun envisioning post-canon fates for Hordak and Entrapta as well as Catra and the other princesses. I hope you've derived enjoyment from reading this as much as I did from writing it. And I hope you're as satisfied with my conclusion for Hordak and Entrapta as I am.
>
> This chapter is dedicated to my aunt who has recently being diagnosed with advanced cancer. My thoughts are with you on the other side of the world, Auntie B.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The glow of purple power lines emitted from Hordak's arm-mounted cannon and the vivid red luminescence of his eyes were the only sources of light as he and Entrapta walked in darkness through the First Ones temple's corridor. Hordak felt his free hand being caught and held reassuringly by the familiar silky strands of Entrapta's hair, guiding him behind her as she led him forward.

It wasn't long until they reached another metal door, promptly opened with the press of another button that Entrapta quickly found. The door slid open to reveal a cavernous, dimly lit hall that contained a giant computer screen. The giant computer stood over a suspended circular platform, reached via a walkway stretching out in front of them. All around lay black vines, covering the floor and walls.

"The signal originates from somewhere around here and is particularly potent," Entrapta warned, staring mutely at the vines

ahead of them. Her voice quietened: "I nearly stayed here…If not for Adora and Bow…"

Hordak raised his gleaming silver arm cannon and directed it at the vine-covered walkway. Its purple power lines lit up as it charged for firing.

"You will never come to harm again," he growled lowly.

A wide beam of purple energy shot out from the cannon, striking the walkway and burning away the vines covering it. When he lifted his smoking cannon again, the walkway had been cleared. Only the burnt stubs of vines remained at the edges.

Hordak turned to Entrapta with a smirk and a glint in his eye.

"Consider your new weapon successfully tested, Beloved," he said with a small show of sharp red teeth.

She gazed back at him dreamily.

"**Very** successfully," she swooned.

With a soft, broadening smile, he lifted his hand to her. Matching his smile, she slid her gloved fingers into his waiting palm. Hand in hand, gazing fondly at one another, they proceeded to make their way over the cleared walkway toward the circular platform, coming to a stop before the giant computer screen.

Knowingly, Hordak released his beloved's hand as her long lilac hair began to ripple in familiar excitement at the sight of the giant computer. He smiled to himself as she vaulted herself over to it on her extending pigtails, then turned to him with a gleeful grin.

"Ta daaah! Here it is!" she declared with a flourish of her hands and floating hair.

"An ancient supercomputer…," Hordak observed with interest.

Hair separating into multiple tendrils over the computer's control keys, Entrapta set to work activating it, swiftly tapping at the keys with hair tendrils as well as her fingers. The giant computer powered up and lines of First Ones coding appeared on the screen.

"Yes! All the information on the First Ones we could ever want is right here!" she exclaimed exuberantly as she stared up at the giant screen raptly. "This is where I learnt about how they controlled She-Ra and created the Heart of Etheria!"

"Impressive indeed," Hordak remarked, gazing up at the giant computer in fascination.

Entrapta's gloved hands squeezed into fists at her sides as she squealed with delight:

"Isn't it just? And there's so much more to be learnt! We could find out how the First Ones came to Etheria long ago! What technology they used to travel! How they built their spaceships! Their portals! Even where they came from originally!"

Lifting herself up on her hair, she twirled joyfully and threw her arms out.

"Oh, just imagine the possibilities!" she cried ecstatically. "We could create our own spaceships! Build a new portal! Explore the universe! Find the First Ones' home world! The stars would be the limit!" Her words tumbled from her mouth.

She cackled manically, falling backwards into Hordak's arms. He let out a deep chuckle as he caught her, her exuberance and joy infecting him as well.

"Yeees, unlimited possibilities at our fingertips," he concurred with a devious smile.

He brought her small body against his plated chest where the fuchsia First Ones crystal glowed steadily. Their eyes, vibrant red and sparkling magenta, connected. Her gloved fingers sought the

fuchsia crystal she had given him, rising to touch it. In turn, his clawed fingers reached for the blue First Ones crystal on her chest, laying upon it.

He had discovered the blue crystal here on Beast Island and given it to her, a token of his undying devotion and the affections he returned to her. Worn over their hearts, the crystals now symbolized their bond as life partners.

He gazed down at her affectionately. "You truly are brilliant, My Queen."

She smiled vibrantly back up at him. Tendrils of her lilac hair curled around him, gripping him tightly.

"**We're** brilliant, Hordak," she corrected. "And together, we're capable of anything."

She drew him down towards her with her hair. Her gloved hands reached up to hold his cheeks, guiding his face down to hers. Entranced by her beauty, he offered no resistance to her draw.

"Yes, anything…," he murmured, watching intently as her pink lips approached.

Their lips joined, softly, warmly, moulding intimately around one another. His tall ears fluttered as her small fingers delicately stroked the sensitive edges. Closing their eyes, they savoured their moment of connection.

This was what she had left the other princesses for. This was what he had turned against his brother for. This was what they had given up everything for.

This connection, this bond.

This love.

A love that was not only given, but also returned. A love which gave them the freedom to be themselves for one another.

The kiss broke and their lips separated. But Hordak hovered above her face, panting heavily with the strain of his fast-beating heart.

"I would do anything for you," he whispered breathily. "I would claim the stars for you. I would conquer the world of the First Ones and others if it would please you."

As she smiled up at him, more dazzling than the stars, he knew he had meant what he said: he would do **anything** for her.

"I love you too, Hordak," she said in a soft, tiny voice, just for him. "I'd be so happy just to create new technology and explore the universe with you." Tears of happiness formed from the corners of her magenta eyes.

Gently, he took hold of her gloved hand and lifted it to his lips, kissing her fingers fervently. Then he looked at her again with firm resolve.

"Then that is what you shall have, My Queen," he promised, "the technology of the First Ones and the universe for your delight."

Suddenly, Entrapta pulled herself up with her hair around him and proceeded to throw her arms around his neck. She let out a small squeak of happiness as she hugged him tightly, pressing herself against him. His tall ears flicked in surprise, but a smile spread across his thin lips. He wrapped his long arms around her, returning her hug. And lowering his head, he rested it upon the top of hers, nuzzling contentedly into her hair.

With smiles on their faces, they looked back up at the giant computer where lines of ancient First Ones coding ran across the screen in gold. The gold symbols began to shift and reform themselves into a circular shape.

"It's going to be amazing!" Entrapta squealed, joyful tears filling her eyes.

The gold symbols on the large screen settled into a circle, transforming into an image of a gold planet. Above it, an encircled

combination of First Ones symbols glowed brightly.

As he stared transfixed at the gold planet on the screen, Hordak began to utter: “This world is…”

Entrapta’s magenta eyes grew large, sparkling under the gold planet’s glow.

“The home world of the First Ones…,” she exhaled in wonder, “Eternia.”

Chapter End Notes

Did you really think Beast Island could contain Hordak and Entrapta for long? With their combined intellects and the information and tech available on the island, it was only a matter of time before they found ways to escape Etheria.

One of my main aims for this fic was to develop Hordak and Entrapta’s agency and self-determination. I wanted to give them the opportunity to control their own fates and make their own choices. We followed Adora and Catra’s stories of finding agency and making choices, good and bad, for themselves throughout the show. I wanted to extend the same treatment to Hordak and Entrapta here by having them decide their own paths post-canon.

Throughout the show, we’ve seen Hordak and Entrapta being the victims of misfortunes beyond their control. Entrapta was (unintentionally) abandoned by the princesses in the Fright Zone, tased and sent off to Beast Island by Catra and left there, and misunderstood by the other princesses. Hordak was sent away to die by his creator for his defects, stranded for years on Etheria, lost his only real friend in Entrapta, deceived and manipulated by Catra, and finally reconditioned into Horde Prime’s slave once again.

Leaving behind the princesses and civilised Etheria to create a new life for themselves on Beast Island was something I wanted Hordak and Entrapta to decide for themselves,

independent of others. After all the hurt and tragedy they've been through as a result of things beyond their control in the show, they deserved to finally take charge of their own lives.

And with that, readers, I give thanks to you all for joining me with this fic. Thanks so much to all my lovely commenters and kudos-leavers. If you've enjoyed reading this, I'd love to hear your thoughts. And if you like my writing, you can check out my older works. I'll probably take a bit of break for now, but I hope to get round to working on some other ideas I've had. Keep a lookout for my future fics!

Be well and happy, friends. Keep yourselves safe and be kind to others. See you around!

End Notes

Remember, your kudos and comments are my food! Thanks for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!